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Leaders of Tomorrow

Real stories from 15 school leaders who are shaping the future of education - one bold decision at a time.

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Leaders
of
Tomorrow

Voices from the Field

Real Stories from 15 School Leaders Shaping
the Future of Education

Curated by TomoClub

Tomorrow Innovations Inc
Dublin, Ohio

Leaders of Tomorrow: Voices from the Field

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For every educator who chose this work
not because it was easy,
but because the children were worth it.

And for the communities that trusted them
to build something better.

“The future of education will not be built by those who stand on the sidelines and critique. It will be built by those who walk the hallways, sit with the families, and do the work.”

— Leaders of Tomorrow

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

This book is not meant to be read cover to cover in one sitting — though you certainly can. It is designed as a reference guide you return to whenever you need it.

The 15 chapters are organized into five leadership dimensions. Each section represents a role that school leaders must navigate, often in the same week:

Part I — The Ambassador: How to navigate school board politics, community dynamics, and the public square without losing your integrity or your mind.

Part II — The Cultivator: How to build teams, develop talent, and make the hardest personnel decisions with both courage and compassion.

Part III — The Builder: How to turn around struggling schools, create alternative environments, and ensure every student feels safe and seen.

Part IV — The Pathfinder: How to connect classrooms to the real world through career readiness systems and a compelling vision for graduates.

Part V — The Innovator: How to reimagine the fundamentals — calendars, curricula, and instruction — when the old models no longer serve every student.

Start wherever you need to. If you are in the middle of a board crisis, turn to The Ambassador. If you are struggling with a teacher who is not meeting the bar, go to The Cultivator. If you just took over a turnaround school, The Builder is for you.

Each chapter stands alone. Each one was written by a leader who lived it. And each one ends with ideas you can put to use on Monday morning.

Keep this book within arm's reach. You will need it more than once.

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15 Chapters · 15 Authors · 5 Leadership Dimensions

Real stories. Real leaders. Real impact.

GENESIS

The Story Behind This Book

And Why It Matters Now More Than Ever

A collection of real stories from the school leaders
who are shaping the future of education—from within.

GENESIS

A FIELD UNDER SIEGE

Education has been pushed to its breaking point.

Since the pandemic upended every classroom in the world, educators and school leaders have not had a single moment to catch their breath. The ground has not stopped shifting. COVID-19 forced an overnight reinvention of how learning happens, and before anyone could process that upheaval, a cascade of new disruptions arrived—each one demanding answers that nobody fully had.

During the pandemic, hundreds of edtech companies rushed in with bold promises to revolutionize learning outcomes. Most of them are gone now. They failed because they treated education like a software problem—something you could disrupt with a slick interface and a growth-hacking playbook. But education is not a product. It is a living, breathing ecosystem. It is a reflection of culture, community, identity, and the deepest aspirations families hold for their children. You cannot reduce that to a dollar value. You cannot optimize it with an algorithm.

And yet, the disruptions keep coming. Artificial intelligence is now rewriting the conversation about what students need to learn and what skills will matter in five years, ten years, a lifetime. Education Savings Accounts are reshaping the competitive landscape, giving parents more choice and forcing public schools to reimagine themselves in a world where enrollment is no longer guaranteed and funding follows the family, not the building. Federal departments face restructuring. Metrics are being challenged. The rules that governed public education for decades are being rewritten in real time.

It is a lot. And that is an understatement.

> *"Education is not a problem to be solved by outsiders looking in. It is a calling to be lived by those who show up every day for children."*

HOW WE GOT HERE

We were born in the aftermath.

When the edtech bubble burst and the dust settled, we did not see an industry to disrupt. We saw classrooms full of children who needed people in their corner. We saw teachers who had given everything during the hardest years of their careers and were still being asked for more. We saw school leaders carrying the weight of their communities on their shoulders, navigating political minefields with one hand and comforting grieving families with the other.

We started with a simple, stubborn conviction: our students deserve to be future-ready, and the people best positioned to make that happen are already inside the schools. Not outside consultants parachuting in with frameworks that vanish when the contract ends. Not technology vendors selling solutions to problems they have never personally faced. The educators. The principals. The superintendents. The people who chose this work because they believe in it.

We are products of this system ourselves. We grew up in these classrooms. We learned from teachers who cared about us before we knew how to care about ourselves. And because of that, we knew something that many of the would-be disruptors never understood: you do not fix education by bashing the system from the outside. You strengthen it by working alongside the people who make it run.

So that is what we did.

We built a Future-Ready Skills Curriculum designed around the capabilities that no technology can replace, leadership, innovation, resilience, collaboration, emotional intelligence, ethical reasoning, creative problem-solving. The very things that make us irreplaceably human in an age of machines. We launched teacher training programs on AI integration, because

educators should be leading the conversation about technology in learning, not chasing it. We developed AI literacy programs for middle and high school students, because the next generation should understand the tools that will shape their world.

But the work that changed us most was the work we did not plan.

LISTENING BEFORE LEADING

Five years ago, we started having conversations. Not presentations. Not webinars. Conversations.

We launched a podcast and began sitting down with the people doing the hardest, most important work in education—superintendents, principals, chief academic officers, curriculum directors, educators from public schools, independent schools, charter schools, and homeschooling organizations. We listened. We asked them what kept them up at night and what got them out of bed in the morning. We asked about classroom engagement, post-pandemic behavioral challenges, technology innovation, leadership under pressure, family and community engagement, career readiness, and what the future of schools could look like if we dared to imagine it.

We crossed 150 episodes. And somewhere along the way, something remarkable happened.

A community formed. Not because we marketed it or built a funnel. It formed because school leaders are hungry—genuinely hungry—to learn from each other. They want to know how the superintendent three states away handled a board crisis. They want to hear how a principal in a rural district turned around a school culture that everyone had written off. They want proof that the work they are doing matters, and they want the honest, messy, human details of how other leaders are navigating the same storms.

To deepen this, we created an Educational Hall of Fame—a space where we spotlight schools and leaders, collaborate with them on articles about their innovations, and share those stories with the wider community. It became a place of recognition, yes, but

more importantly, a place of connection. A place where leaders could see themselves in each other's struggles and victories.

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

It started with something a guest said after we stopped recording.

We had just finished an episode that left both of us sitting in silence for a moment. The story was that powerful. And the guest looked at us and said, *"You should publish a book. These stories deserve more than a podcast episode. They deserve a place people can return to."*

That idea stayed with us. And then other guests said the same thing. And then we realized they were right.

The book you are holding is not a textbook. It is not a policy brief or an academic paper. It is a collection of real stories from real school leaders who are solving real problems in their communities right now. Each chapter is written by a leader who has earned their insights the hard way—through late nights, tough conversations, failed experiments, and the kind of persistence that only comes from loving the work even when the work is brutal.

These are not theoretical frameworks. These are battle-tested strategies from the trenches of American education.

WHAT YOU WILL FIND INSIDE

We have organized this book around the roles that every great school leader must learn to play, sometimes all in the same day. Each section represents a dimension of leadership that our authors have mastered through experience, and each chapter offers a window into how they did it.

THE AMBASSADOR: Navigating Politics, Community, and the Public Square

School leadership does not happen in a vacuum. It happens in school board meetings, community forums, media cycles, and political minefields. Dr. Al Lewis shares the hard-won lessons from his superintendent's office on building trust with school boards, not through politics, but through the quiet discipline of relationships. Dr. Melvin J. Brown offers a complementary and uncompromising perspective on navigating the same terrain with boldness and conviction. Dr. Robert Tremblay brings the art of educational diplomacy to life through vivid storytelling. And Bill Runey reveals what it truly takes to build authentic partnerships with families and communities, the kind that survive budget seasons and board elections.

THE CULTIVATOR: Building People, Building Culture

Great schools are built by great teams, and great teams do not happen by accident. Chris Shearer delivers a masterclass in building empowered, resilient leadership teams, with practical scripts, common pitfalls, and the kind of clarity that comes from doing the work, not just writing about it. Dr. Keisha Scarlett contributes what may be the most powerful chapter in this collection: a story that is insanely inspiring, deeply personal, and a testament to the transformative leaders who are often hidden in plain sight. And Dr. Leslie Sparacello confronts one of the most uncomfortable realities in school leadership head-on: what do you do when a teacher is not meeting the bar? Her chapter, Help Them Grow or Help Them Go, is a courageous and compassionate framework for developing struggling educators while protecting the students and culture that depend on quality instruction in every classroom.

THE BUILDER: Turnaround and School Climate -Rebuilding What Others Have Given Up On

Some schools need more than improvement. They need transformation. Yaw Obeng shares the raw, honest story of a superintendent's turnaround, the calculated risks, the resistance, and the breakthroughs that come when a leader

refuses to accept failure as permanent. Kevin Scanlon challenges us to confront a truth that too many systems avoid: not every child can be successful in the same environment, and creating alternatives is not giving up, it is an act of profound respect. Will Pickens brings a guardian's perspective to school safety, wellness, and belonging, reminding us that a school's climate is not a nice-to-have—it is the foundation upon which everything else stands.

THE PATHFINDER: Connecting Schools to the Real World

What happens after graduation? Curtis Clough makes the case for systemic change thinking, building career readiness not as an add-on but as a fundamental design principle across the entire K–12 system. David Y. Verdugo shares how to design a system that actually delivers on the promises we make to students and families through a compelling Portrait of a Graduate.

THE INNOVATOR: Reimagining What School Can Be

Dr. Mark Sullivan delivers one of the most gripping chapters in this book, the story of reimagining the school calendar, told with the compassion and grit of someone who fought for every single change. Dr. Noel Schmidt shows what it looks like to deliver world-class education in unexpected places, on the range, far from the resources that urban districts take for granted. And Dr. Debbie Brockett brings essential expertise on differentiating instruction for neurodiverse learners, reminding us that innovation is not always about technology, sometimes it is about finally seeing every student in the room.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

This book is for the superintendent who just got off a three-hour board meeting and is sitting alone in their car, wondering if any of it mattered. It is for the principal who is two years into a turnaround and cannot yet see the light. It is for the assistant

superintendent who dreams of the top job but is not sure they are ready. It is for the curriculum director who knows the system needs to change but does not know where to start.

It is for the veteran who needs to be reminded why they chose this work. And it is for the newcomer who needs to know that choosing this work is one of the most important decisions they will ever make.

Think of this book as a reference guide you keep within arm's reach. Not something you read once and shelve. Something you return to when you are stuck, when you need a jolt of inspiration, when you need to hear another leader's voice saying: I have been there, and here is what I learned.

A NOTE OF GRATITUDE

Every author in this book is someone who has made a genuine dent in the educational landscape. They are superintendents, principals, and system leaders who have turned around failing schools, navigated impossible politics, built cultures from scratch, and reimagined what education can be, not in theory, but in practice, with real students and real communities counting on them.

They did not have to share their stories. They chose to. They opened up about their failures as much as their victories, because they know that honesty is what makes a story useful, not just impressive. We are deeply grateful for their generosity, their vulnerability, and their unwavering commitment to the profession they love.

Education is, right now, as dynamic and challenging as it has ever been. The disruptions are real. The pressures are enormous. The stakes could not be higher.

But here is what we have learned from five years of conversations with the people who do this work: the best school leaders are not waiting for the storm to pass. They are building in the storm.

They are adapting, innovating, and leading with a ferocity that comes from knowing that every decision they make ripples through the lives of children and families for generations.

This book is our small contribution to that effort. We hope it inspires you. We hope it challenges you. And most of all, we hope it reminds you that in a field full of noise and disruption, the most powerful force in education has always been the same thing: a dedicated leader who refuses to give up on their students.

> *"The future of education will not be built by those who stand on the sidelines and critique. It will be built by those who walk the hallways, sit with the families, and do the work."*

With passion and purpose,

Avinash Bansal & Manik Mehta

Co-Founders, TomoClub

PART I

THE AMBASSADOR: NAVIGATING POLITICS, COMMUNITY & TRUST

Navigating the Political Minefield: Working with Your School Board

Lessons Learned from the Superintendent's Office

By Dr. Al Lewis

About the Author



Dr. Al Lewis currently serves as the Superintendent of the Glassboro Public School District, where his leadership is defined by a deep-seated commitment to servant leadership and community-centric progress. With his doctorate in educational leadership, Dr. Lewis has spent over two decades championing equity and innovation across South Jersey. His professional journey is marked by a series of transformative roles, including a highly successful tenure as the Superintendent of Weymouth Township School District. Under his guidance, the district achieved a nationally recognized turnaround, stabilizing fiscal operations and restoring community trust through a "people-first" approach. This work earned him the prestigious 2024 National Association of School Superintendents (NASS) Excellence in Small School District Leadership Award.

Beyond the administrative office, Dr. Lewis is a mentor and coach; he serves as the head coach for a youth women's ice hockey team and remains active in local service. His contributions to this work are rooted in the belief that educational leadership should focus on creating inclusive, nurturing cultures where both staff and students can thrive with integrity and purpose.

Introduction

I did not expect to be a superintendent; in fact, I would have bet money that I'd never have pursued an administrative role, let alone the top spot in our field. But my plans are not the real plans, and I am truly blessed to be a superintendent. I was well prepared to enter the field. I am the proud product of Rowan University's College of Education, a nationally recognized institution that has produced phenomenal teachers and leaders for over 100 years. A few weeks shy of my 23rd birthday, I entered my very first teaching assignment and hoped to enjoy a long career as a teacher. I had zero ambition to be an administrator, but after a few years of teaching, I found I wanted to expand my ability to help students. I began to see how serving a school as a principal would allow me to help hundreds of children each year, rather than 25. At 28, I was appointed to my first administrative position, Curriculum Supervisor in New Jersey's largest K-8 school district. I suddenly went from supervising 25 fifth graders to supervising programs taught by 600+ teachers spread across eleven schools. As fate would have it, at 37, I was appointed to my first superintendency in a small, rural school district. After three years in service, I was appointed as superintendent of a medium-sized school district. Along with each administrative role and district, I have worked with over one hundred board of education members, have served as a board member in my town of residence, and have learned a few humbling lessons along the way.

I learned very quickly that success as a superintendent is not solely about instructional leadership, budget management, or strategic planning. Those skills matter, but they only function well when the superintendent–board relationship is healthy. When it is not, everything slows down, becomes harder, or grinds to a halt. When that happens, children, staff, families, and the community suffer.

This chapter is not theoretical. It is reflective. These are lessons learned through experience. Through moments when I handled things well and others where I wished I had done better. These lessons come from board meetings that went smoothly

and those that kept me replaying conversations long after everyone left the building. They are shaped by serving in different districts, working with various different boards, navigating elections, managing crises, and growing into a role that can quickly overtake every other aspect of your life.

If there is one thing I wish someone had told me early on, it is this: board work is less about politics and more about interpersonal relationships. When you understand that, everything changes.

Lesson One: Your School Board Is Not One Entity

Early in my career, I made a quiet but consequential assumption. I believed the school board functioned as a single audience. I prepared presentations as if the phrase "the board" meant one body with shared priorities, shared knowledge, and a single way of processing information. I assumed that if the message was strong and well prepared, it would land the same way with everyone. It did not.

What I eventually learned is that boards vote as a collective, but they think as individuals. Every member arrives with a different story and a different reason for putting their name on the ballot. Some ran because of an issue involving their own child. Some ran out of concern for finances. Some feel deeply connected to staff and school culture. Others view their role almost entirely through a governance lens. Some want to be visible and involved. Others prefer distance. Some are political by nature. Others are relational and community-driven.

My early mistake was not disagreement. It was overgeneralization. I failed to invest enough time in understanding how differently board members processed information. Once I shifted toward intentional one-on-one conversations, the dynamic began to change. Not because everyone agreed more, but because trust increased.

Over time, I began to recognize natural groupings within boards.

Parents often approached decisions through personal experience and emotion, filtering district-level issues through the lens of their own children.

Retirees tended to take a longer view, focusing on fiscal responsibility and the community's overall sustainability.

Board members with educational backgrounds processed information differently from those without such experience, often making assumptions about school operations that non-educators understandably did not share.

Members with leadership or management experience wanted to understand systems, risks, and long-term impact.

Others needed clear explanations for why specific processes existed at all.

This did not mean telling different stories to different people. It meant explaining the same decision through different lenses.

I learned to tailor my communication so that each member could access the reasoning behind a recommendation from their perspective.

With parents, I grounded conversations in the impact on students and families. With financially focused or retired members, I emphasized long-term implications and stewardship. With educators, I spoke about instructional coherence, staffing realities, and professional practice. With board members who lacked leadership experience, I slowed down and explained processes that once felt self-evident to me but were not necessarily intuitive to them.

This shift came gradually and not without frustration. I started noticing that confusion or resistance during meetings almost always stemmed from misunderstandings that could have been addressed beforehand. That realization changed how I prepared.

I became far more intentional about individual conversations ahead of important agenda items. These were not efforts to engineer votes. They were efforts to surface questions, anticipate

concerns, and eliminate uncertainty before it played out publicly. Sometimes those conversations happened informally. Other times, they happened in committee settings where board members felt more comfortable expressing hesitation or asking basic questions.

Those conversations became especially important when decisions were complicated, emotionally charged, or expensive. Capital projects. Staffing realignments. Major program investments. Anything with a significant price tag or visible impact. I learned that if confusion or emotion were not addressed privately and in advance, it would surface at the board table, amplified by the pressure of a public audience.

Getting ahead of those moments was not about persuasion. It was about preparation. I started painting a vivid picture by saying , “This is why I am recommending this, and this is what I imagine might feel uncomfortable.” **Naming discomfort early made it easier to manage later.**

As I invested more time in understanding individual board members, trust deepened. Not because consensus suddenly appeared, but because board members felt respected and informed. They became more willing to ask questions. More willing to admit uncertainty. More willing to trust that recommendations were thoughtful and grounded.

Along the way, I refined the questions I asked in one-on-one conversations. What brought you into this role? What worries you most right now? What does success look like from your seat? What information would help you feel more confident about this decision?

Understanding the people did not mean catering to them or surrendering professional judgment. It meant leading them effectively. Leadership, I understand now, is not just about being right. It is about helping people understand why something makes sense to them.

That lesson reshaped how I approached every board interaction that followed.

Lesson Two: Transparency is a Powerful Tool When Used Correctly

I came into the superintendency with a strong belief in transparency. As a matter of principle, I have always believed that public education deserves public trust, and that trust is built through openness rather than control. The district does not belong to the superintendent. It belongs to the community. My role, from the beginning, was not to guard information but to steward it responsibly.

What experience has taught me is not whether transparency mattered, but how powerful it becomes when it is used intentionally and consistently.

Early on, I recognized that boards struggle to govern well when they do not fully understand the complexity of the decisions superintendents are hired to make. Staffing, budgeting, facilities, legal mandates, student supports, and instructional systems rarely present clean or simple choices. Without transparency, these decisions can appear arbitrary or reactive. With openness, they become understandable, even when they are difficult.

This principle came to life in various ways.

Hiring Practices: For significant leadership positions, I made a conscious decision to invite board members to observe interview processes. Their role was not to influence outcomes or evaluate candidates, but to understand the rigor, professionalism, and thoughtfulness behind the decisions. Watching the process unfold helped board members see how leadership qualities were assessed and why final recommendations were made. That shared understanding reduced skepticism and strengthened confidence in difficult personnel decisions.

Operational and Strategic Issues: When I saw early signs that a decision could become publicly sensitive, financially significant, or emotionally charged, I brought board members

into the conversation sooner rather than later. I shared the relevant context, constraints, options, and professional judgment well before a formal agenda item appeared. This was not about abdicating responsibility or asking for permission. It was about equipping the board with the information they needed to govern responsibly.

Over time, I learned to leverage transparency to explain complexity rather than defend outcomes. Board members are paying the superintendent to manage complexity on their behalf. Transparency allows them to see the problem-solving behind the scenes, not just the final recommendation. When that understanding exists, confusion decreases, and emotional reactions are less likely to surface during public meetings.

This approach was informed by my view of the superintendent's role. I view the position as one of stewardship. The superintendent is entrusted with public resources, public confidence, and the well-being of children and staff. Stewardship demands clarity, honesty, and openness. When information is withheld or filtered too tightly, trust deteriorates. When information is shared thoughtfully and professionally, relationships strengthen.

Transparency also proved essential during challenging moments. There were times when the answers were incomplete, or the path forward was uncertain. Being honest about what was known, what was still being examined, and how decisions would be evaluated over time reinforced credibility. Board members may not always like the circumstances, but they respect integrity.

Experience affirmed for me that transparency does not weaken leadership. It strengthens it. Used correctly, transparency builds trust, prepares board members for informed decision making, and reinforces the superintendent's role as a trusted professional advisor. It moves governance away from suspicion and toward partnership.

That lesson continues to guide how I lead today

Lesson Three: Never Surprise Your Board in Public

I learned this lesson once, and once was enough.

Even when a recommendation is sound and procedurally appropriate, introducing new information publicly without prior awareness almost always creates unintended consequences. Board members do not appreciate feeling unprepared in front of their community. What may feel like efficiency to a superintendent often feels like exposure to an elected official.

Surprises in public settings generate embarrassment, defensiveness, and sometimes resentment. They shift attention away from the substance of an issue and toward the discomfort of the moment. The most well-reasoned recommendation can become secondary to how a board member feels when they are caught off guard.

That experience fundamentally changed how I approached board communication. I began sharing context early, especially when an item was complex, sensitive, or likely to prompt questions. This did not mean seeking approval or testing the waters politically. It meant creating awareness. A brief phone call. A message. A quiet explanation delivered ahead of time. Those small gestures prevented unnecessary conflict later.

I learned that certainty and surprises cannot coexist. When board members understand the issue, even disagreement is manageable. When they are surprised, even good ideas are scrutinized through a defensive lens.

This approach became particularly important for decisions involving finances, personnel, or public perception. Anything that required board members to explain a decision to their constituents deserved advance context. When questions arose, they were no longer blindsided. They were prepared.

Giving board members time to process also allowed emotions to settle before public discussion. Initial reactions, concerns, or misunderstandings could be addressed privately rather than amplified at the board table. The result was not unanimity, but professionalism.

Over time, I learned to view advanced communication not as extra work, but as essential leadership. It honored the board's role. It protected the relationship. It strengthened governance.

Transparency builds partnership. Surprises fracture it.

Lesson Four: Public Comment Is About Democracy, Not Accuracy

Public comment can be one of the most challenging aspects of the superintendent role. Emotions run high. Comments may be incomplete, misinformed, or critical. At times, they can feel deeply personal. Early in my career, my instinct was to correct the record. I believed that accuracy equaled leadership and that leaving statements unchallenged weakened credibility.

What experience taught me instead is that public comment is not about precision. It is about voice.

Over time, I learned to focus less on responding and more on listening. When people step to the microphone, they are often carrying emotion shaped by personal experience, fear, or frustration. Before anyone is ready to hear facts or explanations, they want validation that their feelings matter. I learned to acknowledge emotion first and promise to follow up privately when appropriate. That simple shift changed interactions from confrontation to conversation.

I also learned something more difficult and more important. Effective leadership requires the ability to let people be wrong.

Community members do not always have the full story. In many cases, they cannot have the full story. Laws, ethics, and professional responsibility restrict what can be shared about personnel issues, student matters, and sensitive situations. Early on, that felt unfair. Over time, I learned to see it as a test of leadership.

Confidence as a superintendent means being able to stand in discomfort without defensiveness. It means allowing others to

express frustration or anger without needing to correct them publicly. It means being secure enough to let emotion exist without needing to win the moment. I grew more comfortable allowing inaccuracies to stand in that space, knowing that dignity mattered more than debate.

Correcting people publicly rarely resolves anything. It often strips them of dignity and puts leaders into arguments they should not be having. Instead, I became more intentional about following up through appropriate channels. Private conversations. Official communications. Context shared with the board. Those avenues allowed for clarity without public embarrassment.

This approach required discipline and courage. It meant trusting that my leadership was not defined by a single exchange or comment. It meant believing that consistency, transparency, and professionalism over time build far more credibility than momentary rebuttals.

Public comment is democracy in action. It is messy and imperfect by design. When superintendents honor that space by listening first, validating emotion, and protecting dignity, they strengthen trust not just with critics, but with the entire community watching.

Lesson Five: Boundaries Protect Everyone

One of the hardest lessons for me to learn was how to set boundaries without damaging relationships. The theory is simple. The practice is not. In real governance work, lines blur easily, especially when board members are highly invested, deeply committed, and motivated by a genuine desire to help.

There were moments when board members crossed into operational territory. Not out of malice or ego, but confusion about where governance ends and management begins. Early on, I learned that avoiding these situations in the name of peace does not preserve relationships. It slowly erodes them. Unclear

boundaries create uncertainty for staff, confusion for board members, and risk for students.

One moment stands out clearly. A board member once asked for a hard hat with a district logo so they could personally supervise a construction site on school grounds. The intent was not harmful. The board member wanted to be visible, helpful, and engaged. But the request represented an inappropriate role shift and a misuse of district funds. More importantly, it created legal and professional risk.

That was a moment where leadership required firmness. I denied the request. I explained clearly and respectfully why board members cannot supervise operational work, why construction oversight sits within administrative responsibility, and why even well-intentioned involvement can introduce liability. It was an uncomfortable conversation, but it was necessary. Avoiding it would have created far greater problems down the line.

There were other moments where clarity was equally critical. I have stood my ground when a board member's involvement or misunderstanding would reasonably cause harm to staff morale or student well-being. Whether it involved personnel concerns, discipline issues, or direct engagement with staff outside appropriate channels, the responsibility to protect people rested with me.

Those situations forced me to grow. Early in my career, I worried too much about how I would be perceived. Over time, I learned that clarity is kindness. It is possible to speak firmly and concisely about roles without being dismissive. Referencing policies, statutes, and governance expectations helps remove personality from the conversation and place responsibility where it belongs.

At the same time, setting boundaries does not mean closing doors. I learned that the strongest boundary conversations are paired with transparency and appropriate involvement. When board members understand what is happening, why decisions

are being made, and how they can engage constructively within their role, the desire to cross lines diminishes.

Boundaries are not confrontations. They are professional agreements. When reinforced calmly, privately, and consistently, they protect governance, leadership, staff, and students alike. They allow everyone to operate with confidence and clarity, which is ultimately what strong boards and strong superintendents need to succeed.

Lesson Six: Use Data as Part of Your District's Story

Emotion drives politics. Data grounds decisions.

Over time, I came to see the superintendent not just as the chief executive, but as the district's chief storyteller. Storytelling does not replace data. It depends on it. Data provides the backbone of district decision making. It gives structure, credibility, and clarity. But data alone is rarely enough. It needs to be brought to life through the lived experiences of the people behind the numbers.

I learned that when conversations intensified or positions hardened, returning to evidence helped slow the discussion and restore focus. Enrollment trends, budget forecasts, achievement patterns, staff retention data, and community feedback gave context beyond individual complaints or isolated anecdotes. Data allowed the board to see patterns instead of problems in isolation.

At the same time, I learned that numbers become meaningful only when they are connected to real stories. A decline in enrollment matters because of its impact on programming and staffing. Achievement data matters because it reflects daily classroom experiences. Retention data matters because it represents people deciding whether to stay and serve the community. By pairing data with authentic stories from staff, students, and families, the narrative became human rather than abstract.

This balance also strengthened strategic planning. At both of my superintendencies, I relied heavily on baseline data during my entry period. Initial data reviews helped establish a shared understanding of where the district was, not where we wished it had been. That collective understanding grounded visioning work in reality. It allowed the board, leadership team, and community to define what success would look like based on evidence rather than assumption.

Baseline data created a starting point for shared ownership. Instead of asking people to buy into a prewritten vision, I used data to invite conversation. Where are we strong. Where are we vulnerable. What does the data suggest our community needs most. Those conversations shaped strategic priorities rooted in the district's mission and vision rather than reactionary politics.

Using data consistently also helped depersonalize difficult decisions. When staffing adjustments or budget shifts were connected back to enrollment trends and long term projections, conversations moved away from blame toward responsibility. Data did not eliminate disagreement, but it reframed it. It shifted discussions from opinion battles to problem solving conversations.

Over time, this approach built credibility. Board members came to expect evidence as part of every major recommendation. Trust grew because decisions were visibly connected to patterns, planning, and purpose.

Data does not replace leadership. It supports it. When superintendents use data as the foundation of the district's story, and pair it with clear vision and authentic human experience, they create a narrative that is both honest and compelling.

Lesson Seven: Embrace Your Role as the Board's Agent

One of the most important shifts in my leadership came when I fully embraced what it means to be the board's agent. Early on, it is easy for superintendents to think of themselves primarily as the face of the district or the sole driver of its direction.

Experience taught me that the most effective superintendents understand their authority flows through governance, not around it.

Being the board's agent does not mean being passive or obedient. It means understanding that the board sets direction and the superintendent executes that direction through professional judgment, expertise, and leadership of the organization. When superintendents lose sight of that relationship, tension follows. When they honor it, trust grows.

I learned to align recommendations clearly with board priorities. Whether the issue involved policy, budgeting, personnel, or program development, I framed decisions through the lens of the goals the board had publicly affirmed goals the board had affirmed publicly. This helped board members see themselves reflected in the work and reinforced shared ownership of outcomes.

Embracing this role also required me to resist the temptation to personalize outcomes. When a recommendation advanced smoothly, it was because governance and leadership were aligned. When a recommendation stalled or failed, it was a signal to listen more carefully to the board's vision and concerns rather than push harder.

I found that clarity reduced conflict. When board members understood that my role was not to pursue individual agendas but to carry out their collective direction responsibly, conversations became more productive. Disagreement still occurred, but it was grounded in policy and purpose rather than mistrust.

At its best, the board agent relationship creates a powerful partnership. The board governs with confidence, and the superintendent leads with professional autonomy. When both roles are honored clearly and consistently, the district benefits from stability, coherence, and shared accountability.

Lesson Eight: The Long Game Matters More Than the Vote

Early in my career, I cared deeply about board votes. I viewed them as visible markers of effectiveness and alignment. Over time, experience refined that thinking without replacing it.

I do work purposefully toward unanimous votes. Consensus matters. Unity strengthens districts, steadies governance, and reinforces public confidence. I seek unanimity through the strategies already outlined in this chapter. Individual conversations. Early transparency. Clear data. Respect for roles. Thoughtful storytelling. Those efforts are not about managing outcomes. They are about preparing people to govern responsibly together.

What changed for me is not the value of unanimity but the definition of success.

Votes happen, and votes pass. Trust determines what happens next. A unanimous decision that damages confidence serves no one. Alignment without trust is fragile. I learned to measure progress by whether relationships were strengthened and understanding was deepened, not just by the final tally.

I also learned not to lose sight of the real work. The goal is not votes. The goal is to improve outcomes for students and to improve outcomes for students and bettering the lives of staff and families. When decisions stay anchored in that purpose, consensus becomes a byproduct rather than an objective.

There were times when recommendations were delayed or revisited in order to preserve trust. Those pauses were not failures. They were investments. Strong relationships made future decisions easier, more thoughtful, and more aligned with district values. As one of my mentors, Dr. Gerry Woehr, used to say, “Do you want to be right, or do you want to win?” I took that to heart. I could be right about an issue, but lose sight of what really mattered. When we grow the community, do right by students and families, support our employees, and grow the community, – we all win.

Leadership in a board governed system is long-term work. Consensus building matters, but it is not the end. When the superintendent keeps the mission at the center and relationships intact, unanimity becomes meaningful and progress becomes sustainable.

Lesson Nine: Take Care of Yourself If You Want to Last

Board politics are exhausting in ways that are hard to explain until you live them. The meetings end, the votes happen, the emails slow down, but the weight does not disappear. Early in my career, I operated as if endurance alone was enough. If I just worked harder, stayed later, responded faster, and absorbed more, everything would be fine. It wasn't.

What I eventually learned is that burnout does not just happen to ineffective superintendents who are ineffective. It often happens to the most committed ones. The ones who care deeply. The ones who carry the pressure home at night and replay conversations in their heads. The ones who feel personally responsible for every outcome, every criticism, every misstep, whether real or perceived.

I also learned that a burned-out superintendent is not a neutral condition. A tired superintendent becomes reactive. A reactive superintendent becomes defensive. And a defensive superintendent eventually loses clarity, empathy, and perspective. None of that serves students, staff, or the board.

What changed for me was reframing self-care not as a personal indulgence, but as a leadership responsibility.

I am fortunate to have served with boards that understood this. Over time, I learned that the healthiest governance teams care about the superintendent as a whole person. I have worked with board members who reminded me to step away, who checked in not just about work but about family, who encouraged balance instead of glorifying exhaustion. That kind of culture does not happen by accident. It happens when transparency and trust work both ways. When I was open about the demands of the role

and honest about my limits, space was created for a healthier partnership.

At the center of that balance is my family. My wife, Ellen, is the anchor that makes this work possible. She understands the pressures of the job, but she also insists that the job does not get to take everything. She sees the moments when I am carrying too much before I always recognize them myself. Our conversations, our routines, and our shared clarity about priorities help me stay grounded. My kids do the same in a different way. Stellie and Gavin are constant reminders that my title does not define me. They care far more about whether I am present than whether a meeting went well.

Beyond home, I have found other spaces that allow me to exhale. My Thursday night skate with my friends at the EARHL is not just a weekly hockey game. It is a place where I am not a superintendent. There are no agendas, no votes, no public comment. Just brotherhood, competition, laughter, and camaraderie over refreshing beverages. That weekly ice slot has been as therapeutic as any formal strategy I have learned.

Coaching my daughter's hockey team, The Philadelphia Liberties, has given me another kind of balance. Coaching reconnects me to why leadership matters at its most human level. It is about relationships, trust, growth, and joy. It reminds me that leadership is not confined to conference rooms. It lives in locker rooms, on benches, in moments of encouragement, and in helping young people develop confidence and resilience.

These spaces recharge me because they allow me to be fully myself. Not guarded. Not polished. Not strategic. Just human. Just a goalie and a coach (which has always been my favorite title).

Taking care of yourself does not mean disengaging from the work. It means staying healthy enough to do it well over time. It means recognizing that leadership is a marathon, not a series of sprints. It means understanding that longevity brings wisdom and that wisdom benefits everyone.

I used to believe that asking for space or support was a weakness. What I now know is that self-awareness is a strength. Boards want leaders who are steady, clear, and grounded. That steadiness comes from intentional renewal.

If you want to last in this role, you must protect your energy with the same seriousness that you protect your district's mission. You owe that not just to yourself, but to the students, staff, community, and board you serve.

Because leadership is not proven by how much you can carry. It is proven by how long you can lead well.

Lesson Ten and Conclusion: Relationships Are the Real Work

I have grown to understand something that reframed everything that came before it. Working with a school board is not a political game to win. It is a relationship of stewardship.

Most conflicts I experienced were not rooted in policy or procedure. They were rooted in trust. When trust was strong, disagreement stayed professional and productive. When trust was thin, even minor issues felt heavy. Opposition, I learned, was rarely personal. It was contextual. It reflected uncertainty, pressure, incomplete information, or competing responsibilities rather than intent to undermine leadership.

As I reflected on years of board service, one pattern became clear. Boards responded to leadership grounded in clarity, humility, consistency, and humanity. They did not always agree with recommendations. They did not always move as quickly as I might have preferred. But when those core qualities were present, respect remained intact, and the work moved forward.

Clarity matters because uncertainty creates anxiety. When people understand the why behind decisions, they are more willing to engage in honest dialogue. Humility matters because no superintendent leads alone. Acknowledging limits and listening well builds legitimacy rather than weakens it. Consistency matters because trust is cumulative. People believe

what they see repeated over time. Humanity matters because board members, staff, parents, and superintendents are all navigating lives beyond the meeting room.

The work is not easy. It was never meant to be. Public education exists at the intersection of community values, limited resources, and high expectations. Governance reflects that complexity. There will be tension. There will be disagreement. There will be moments of frustration.

But the work is meaningful.

When relationships are prioritized, districts gain stability. When trust is protected, governance becomes purposeful rather than performative. When leadership is steady, students benefit, and staff feel supported. Progress becomes sustainable rather than reactionary.

This chapter is not a formula. It is a reflection on lessons learned along the way. Relationships do not eliminate politics, but they give politics context. They transform board service from conflict management into shared stewardship.

In the end, effective superintendent leadership is not measured by how many votes are won or how many crises are managed. It is measured by whether people believe the work was done with integrity. Whether decisions felt grounded. Whether progress felt collective.

When schools move forward together, with intention and trust, politics do not disappear. They are placed in the service of something better.

That is the work.

The Ambassador: Navigating the Political Minefield

by Dr. Melvin J. Brown

About the Author



Dr. Melvin J. Brown serves as Superintendent in Residence at Defined, bringing decades of leadership experience in large K-12 systems. Drawing on his tenure as superintendent in school districts, he works to advance helping school systems scale career-connected learning from kindergarten through graduation. His work focuses on guiding district leaders to design and implement sustainable, system-wide pathways that prepare every student for lifelong success.

He is also the President and CEO of Soul Vision, LLC, an equity-centered and growth mindset focused consulting organization that provides motivational and keynote speaking, educational consulting, and leadership development. He previously served as Superintendent of Montgomery Public Schools (AL) and of the Reynoldsburg City Schools District in Reynoldsburg, Ohio, from 2017 to 2022. A national advocate for STEM education, he emphasizes the need for community-wide collaboration in student preparation. His leadership focuses on the intersection of equity and technology, ensuring staff are trained in modern trends and students have access to robust wraparound support. An active member of the AASA, Dr. Brown is dedicated to dismantling systemic barriers and providing every child with the opportunity to reach their full potential through rigorous instruction. Dr. Brown is the author of Roaches In My Cereal: And The Moral Imperative to Reimagine School.

Introduction

There comes a moment in every superintendent's leadership journey when the job shows its true shape. It doesn't happen during the high-profile events or ceremonial celebrations. It happens in small, unguarded spaces; after a board meeting that ran too long and said too little, or during a late-night message from someone determined to influence the next day's headlines.

It happens when you realize that you are not only leading a school system. You are managing a political ecosystem.

Superintendents do not simply run districts; they interpret, translate, shield, and represent them. You become the district's ambassador: the communicator-in-chief, the political bridge, the stabilizing force in a landscape that can shift without warning.

This chapter explores that role—the public-facing, negotiation-heavy, communication-saturated dimension of the job that no graduate course or leadership workshop truly prepares you for. The complexity comes from learning that leadership in this role is not solely about technical expertise but about navigating currents of emotion, culture, and history that shape every conversation and every decision. The superintendent operates on multiple stages at once, all while carrying the burden of symbolic leadership, whether they choose to or not.

The Myth of Neutrality

One of the first painful truths superintendents learn is that neutrality is a myth.

We like to imagine that education exists somewhere outside the churn of human politics and personal agendas. We imagine that decisions about literacy, staffing, safety, and strategy can be made with objective clarity. But the moment you step into the seat, you see it clearly:

Every decision in public education carries political weight—even the ones you believe are purely technical.

This reality is often shocking for leaders entering the superintendency from roles where expertise seemed to speak for itself. Suddenly, you find that even the most obvious operational improvements can trigger political interpretations that have nothing to do with the matter at hand. The superintendent must develop the skill to anticipate not only the implications of decisions but also the emotions and narratives they may unintentionally activate.

Every Issue Becomes a Proxy for Something Larger

A school calendar is never just a calendar.

A safety protocol is never just a protocol.

A personnel recommendation is never just staffing.

Each one becomes a container into which people pour their beliefs, fears, and histories.

A school board member may approach an issue not from research or precedent, but from something that happened to their child years ago. A community group may view a policy through the lens of a long-standing cultural shift in the neighborhood. A staff member may react not to your recommendation but to their accumulated distrust of previous leaders.

This means the superintendent operates in an environment where past wounds, past victories, and past controversies are constantly revived, repurposed, or resurfaced. You inherit unresolved tensions without warning. You learn that logic is only one thread in a much larger tapestry of interpretation that includes identity, bias, power, and nostalgia.

The superintendent quickly learns that facts do not operate independently of feeling.

Data does not overshadow memory.

Logic does not erase suspicion.

Neutrality isn't just elusive, it's impossible.

So, the superintendent's role becomes one of navigating not only the decision itself but also the symbolism attached to it. . Understanding this helps leaders avoid the trap of thinking that technical excellence alone will gain support. In truth, emotional intelligence and political awareness are just as essential.

The Boardroom Is Not a Conference Room

Before becoming a superintendent, many leaders imagine a boardroom as a space where professionals gather to reason together, guided by shared purpose.

But the superintendent discovers quickly that the boardroom is **not** a conference room. It is:

- a political arena,
- a community stage,
- a historical archive,
- and sometimes a battleground.

The boardroom reflects the community's identity—its divisions, hopes, and unresolved conflicts. What happens in that room is a reflection of the larger society around it, and often, the superintendent is expected to mediate tensions that extend far beyond educational issues.

You Enter a Story Already in Progress

When you step into the role, you don't begin a new chapter; you enter the middle of one. Board member relationships developed long before you arrived. Some trust each other deeply. Others tolerate one another. Some have long memories, and others have long grudges.

Understanding this is essential because the superintendent often becomes the symbolic recipient of conflicts that were never

about them to begin with. Decisions that should take minutes can stretch into hours because a previous disagreement or personal dynamic resurfaces in subtle ways.

The superintendent often becomes the unwitting carrier of those histories.

You may present a straightforward proposal, and the room reacts in ways that make no rational sense—unless you understand the unspoken context:

- Who disagreed with whom five years ago
- Who lost a campaign battle
- Whose child was affected by a past decision
- Who feels unheard
- Who fears becoming irrelevant.

Board governance is not just policy.

It is interpersonal psychology.

Different Board Members, Different Roles

Some board members see themselves as:

- guardians of taxpayer dollars
- champions of teachers
- protectors of tradition
- advocates for innovation
- representatives of ideological viewpoints

And some see their role as a stepping stone to something larger.

The superintendent must navigate all of these identities without dismissing any of them, even when they conflict. Each board member operates from a mix of values, aspirations, pressure, and public expectations. Ignoring these motivations leaves the superintendent blindsided. Understanding them equips the leader to anticipate actions and mitigate misunderstandings.

The key is understanding:

You cannot control the dynamics.

You can only influence them.
You cannot erase history.
You can only avoid being consumed by it.

Power Without a Vote

One of the most destabilizing realizations for new superintendents is that -they are held responsible for everything but, you have a formal vote on nothing.

You lead, but you do not legislate.
You advise, but you do not rule.
You recommend, but you cannot compel.

This imbalance forces superintendents to rely heavily on soft power, credibility, trust, and relationship-building, rather than formal authority. It also means that leadership is often demonstrated in the margins between influence and decision-making.

Influence Replaces Authority

Because you cannot rely on positional power, your effectiveness emerges from your ability to build influence through relationships, clarity, trust, and consistency.

That influence is fragile:

- One misstep can fracture it.
- One poorly phrased comment can undermine it.
- One board member's change in mood or circumstance can dissolve it.

Thus, the superintendent must constantly invest in relationships, formally and informally. You learn that the most important work may happen in one-on-one conversations, not public meetings. You develop an emotional radar for when to push, when to pause, and when to let someone else take ownership.

The superintendent is constantly balancing the work of vision with the reality of governance. You must learn to persuade

without pushing, to guide without overstepping, and to lead without demanding recognition.

The Superintendency Is Both Public and Personal

Board members evaluate not only your decisions but your disposition.
They react not only to your proposals but to your presence.

This means the superintendent must show up daily with:

- calm,
- preparation,
- emotional steadiness,
- political awareness,
- and humility

Your demeanor becomes part of your leadership strategy. A raised eyebrow, an impatient sigh, or a misinterpreted expression can shift an entire conversation. You cannot afford to be careless with relationships.

In the superintendency, relational equity is currency.

Communication *Is* the Work

Many superintendents mistakenly treat communication as something separate from leadership, as though it is simply an output attached to decisions.

But the truth is this:

Communication is the job.

It is not an accessory to leadership
It is the engine of it.

This is because in the absence of communication, people fill the void with assumptions, assumptions, and assumptions, especially under stress, quickly become narratives. The superintendent must intentionally shape the narrative before rumor does.

Every Message Carries Meaning Beyond Words

When you communicate, people look for:

- reassurance,
- transparency,
- respect,
- and most importantly, intent.

People do not respond to what you say.
They respond to what they believe your words *mean*.

This is why tone, timing, and delivery matter. A hurried email can be misread as indifference. A delayed statement can be interpreted as a sign of secrecy. A perfectly worded message can still fail if it does not account for community fear, fatigue, or polarization.

A simple announcement about staffing can provoke fear. A routine update about the curriculum can ignite suspicion. A calm message about safety can evoke gratitude or panic.

Your communication is constantly interpreted through the community's emotional state, not by the clarity of the text.

Your Tone Becomes the District's Temperature

When a superintendent speaks:

- tension cools or ignites
- rumors shrink or multiply
- trust strengthens or dissolves

Your words cannot solve every problem, but they can keep problems from metastasizing.

Communication is not simply about accuracy.
It is about emotional intelligence.

It is understanding when the community needs detail versus brevity, when people want directness versus empathy, and when silence is dangerous versus strategic.

The Politics of Presence

One of the most profound truths of superintendency is that people will forget many of your decisions, but they will remember your presence.

Presence establishes credibility in ways that memos never can. It signals investment. It communicates humility. It builds goodwill that becomes invaluable when challenging decisions must be made.

Showing Up Is a Leadership Strategy

When community members see their superintendent at:

- school events,
- faith gatherings,
- neighborhood meetings,
- student performances,
- informal conversations,

they feel seen.

And people who feel seen are more willing to trust.

Presence demonstrates that leadership is not confined to administrative offices or boardrooms. It is lived among the people served. It also offers the superintendent valuable informal insight into the district's pulse.

Presence Softens Perception

Being physically present:

- humanizes you
- reduces suspicion
- communicates respect
- builds relational capital

It is far harder for people to villainize a superintendent they have shaken hands with, spoken to, or watched cheering for students.

Presence does not eliminate conflict—
but it reduces caricature.

People stop seeing you as an institution and start seeing you as a person.

That shift can change everything.

And presence isn't only for the community; it matters deeply to staff and students. When the superintendent shows up, it signals that the people doing the work and living the experience matter enough to warrant attention, not only when problems arise.

When Board Governance Breaks Down

Even in the healthiest systems, governance eventually encounters turbulence.

Misalignment is not a sign of failure.
It is a sign of being human.

Board governance is inherently complex because it brings together people with different political alliances, personal histories, motivations, and interpretations of their role. When friction occurs, the superintendent is often the first to feel the tremors.

The Superintendent's Role in Tension

When governance becomes strained, the superintendent must:

- remain calm
- stay neutral without being passive
- keep children at the center
- remind the board of its roles
- maintain professional boundaries

This requires situational awareness and emotional discipline. The superintendent must anticipate tension, name it privately, and navigate it publicly without escalating conflict. You become both participant and mediator, even when you shouldn't have to be.

Conflict Requires Both Distance and Skill

When tensions escalate:

- do not mirror the emotion
- do not escalate rhetoric
- do not take sides
- do not respond with defensiveness

Instead:

- clarify facts
- separate issues from personalities
- resist pressure to assign blame
- redirect the focus toward the strategic mission

This is where the superintendent's emotional maturity becomes vital. You must know when to intervene, when to step back, when to let board members work through their own friction, and when to guide them discreetly toward resolution.

In strained governance, the superintendent's discipline becomes the district's stability.

Community as a Political Actor

Communities behave very much like political coalitions. They form subgroups, amplify narratives, and respond emotionally to events.

This becomes especially apparent in times of change or controversy. Suddenly, individuals who rarely engage make their presence known through calls, emails, social media posts, or public comment. They are activated not only by what you do but by what they fear or imagine might happen next.

The Loudest Voices Shape the Narrative

A handful of outspoken individuals can frame your entire leadership in the public eye. They may not represent the majority, but they influence perception because they are:

- organized
- persistent
- present
- connected

In modern school leadership, narrative travels faster than truth. Small groups can shift momentum simply by being louder and more coordinated than others. As superintendent, you must learn to listen without overreacting, interpret without overcorrecting, and respond without becoming reactive.

Understanding that difference, between loudness and representation, is critical.

Informal Networks Carry Real Power

Communities have:

- text chains,
- church circles,
- parent groups,
- neighborhood associations,
- social media pages

that often function as hidden spaces where opinions form long before you hear them directly.

These spaces shape sentiment. They influence elections. They frame how your message is received. Superintendents must learn to read the emotional climate beneath the surface—to recognize when anxiety is rising, when misinformation is spreading, and when silence is not agreement but fatigue.

Effective superintendents learn to monitor these subtle, informal channels—not to manipulate them, but to understand what people are feeling before it becomes a public crisis.

Crisis Reveals Character

Crisis is the ultimate x-ray of leadership.

In crisis, there is:

- no time to curate
- no time to politic
- no time to rehearse

You are exposed.

The superintendent does not have the luxury of privately processing events. You are thrust into the center of community emotion, fear, anger, confusion, grief, often without complete information or ideal conditions. How you respond becomes part of the district's story.

The Superintendent Becomes the Emotional Anchor

During crisis moments:

- people want reassurance
- people want clarity
- people want accountability
- people want someone to blame, or someone to trust

Your tone sets the district's emotional temperature.
Your steadiness becomes the community's stability.

Even as your phone explodes with messages, as social media distorts the truth, and as pressure mounts from multiple directions, you must remain composed enough to think clearly and compassionate enough to respond humanely.

In a crisis, the superintendent must project:

- calm
- competence
- empathy
- honesty
- presence

Even if internally, you feel the weight of every possible outcome.

Leadership is not the absence of fear.
It is the refusal to transmit it.

Crisis leadership is not only operational—it is profoundly human. The community remembers how you made them feel long after they forget the exact details of the response.

The Cost of Representation

Representation adds layers to the work that many will never see or understand.

It shapes how you are perceived, how your decisions are interpreted, and how your leadership is critiqued. Whether related to race, gender, identity, or lived experience, representation carries both symbolic power and heightened scrutiny.

The Double Visibility of Leadership

When you represent identities that have been historically marginalized or underrepresented in positions of power, the role shifts in subtle but profound ways:

- your presence disrupts expectations
- your decisions are scrutinized differently
- your tone is read through cultural filters
- your mistakes carry heavier consequences
- your success carries symbolic weight

This dynamic is present whether or not it is acknowledged. You become a mirror for some, a symbol for others, and a provocation for those resistant to change. In every interaction—public or private—you carry both your role and your identity, and they shape how others respond to you.

Representation becomes both a responsibility and a vulnerability.

Carrying the Unspoken Expectations

People look to you not only for leadership but for affirmation of identity.
Others watch you with suspicion fueled by bias rather than evidence.

Navigating that duality, serving with authenticity while carrying the weight of expectation, is a quiet, constant labor of the heart.

You must learn to balance:

- visibility with boundaries
- cultural pride with professional expectations
- authenticity with strategic restraint

The superintendent who carries representation must be doubly fluent: able to stand firmly in their identity while recognizing that every action will be interpreted through multiple layers of meaning.

Holding the Line

When you strip away the noise, the superintendent's responsibility is simple, though rarely easy:

Hold the line.

Not a line of rigidity, but a line of integrity.

Holding the line means standing in the tension between what is politically expedient and what is educationally sound. It means absorbing pressure that others cannot bear. It means recognizing that your job is not to survive the role but to serve it.

What It Means to Hold the Line

Holding the line means:

- prioritizing children above politics
- choosing clarity over comfort
- telling the truth even when it costs you
- refusing to weaponize your platform
- absorbing pressure without passing it down
- making decisions rooted in equity
- maintaining your humanity in an inhumane environment

This type of leadership requires stamina; emotional, spiritual, and psychological. It also requires a deep grounding in purpose, because without that grounding, the political winds of the superintendency will push you into postures that betray who you are.

The Ambassador's Real Work

At its core, the superintendent-as-ambassador must:

- unite without erasing difference
- communicate without manipulation
- lead without arrogance
- serve without self-protection
- stay visible without becoming performative

The political minefield is permanent.
The storms are inevitable.
The noise is relentless.

But so is the mission.

The superintendent's work is not to escape politics. It is to lead with such moral clarity, courage, and empathy that the district remains focused on what truly matters:

Its children.

In the end, the superintendent's work is not about managing politics but about protecting possibility—and the courage to do so, day after day, is what keeps hope alive for every child who walks through our doors. Long after the controversies fade and the headlines quiet, what remains are the children we lifted, the communities we steadied, and the future we insisted was worth fighting for.

Becoming an Educational Diplomat

Making Sense of Educational Leadership

By Dr. Robert A. Tremblay

About the Author



With over 25 years of experience, Dr. Robert A. Tremblay serves as Superintendent of Framingham Public Schools and is the founder of an educational consulting firm. He holds doctoral and master's degrees in education and public administration, along with a background in music.

He has worked extensively in leadership development, teaching graduate courses, mentoring aspiring principals and superintendents, and supporting school districts through workshops and coaching. His expertise spans student engagement, school climate, educator evaluation, and organizational change. Dr. Tremblay has also contributed internationally through presentations and school accreditation work across multiple countries. His core passion lies in coaching education leaders to navigate complex, often political environments and effectively drive school and district improvement.

Introduction:

When I think about playing in the political sandbox, I think back to growing up in the late 1970s and the times when my neighborhood friends and I would carve roads and make tunnels and shape the sand in a way that made connections within a system so that we could play with our toy cars and trucks and "make-believe." It was friendly. Playful. Collaborative. We talked and imagined and constructed. Sometimes we got mad and inevitably threw sand at each other before reconciling our differences, but in all of it, there was a transferable skill to what I would come to better understand 40 years later and after many lessons learned, often the hard way: Playing in the sandbox - especially the political one - is actually an art. Playing nicely in the sandbox, however, is an art *form,* and it is what I have spent nearly two decades of my career refining. Now, in my 19th year as a public school superintendent and 30th year as a school- and district-level leader, I continue to apply my own research and findings to my daily work and, as a result, have truly enjoyed nearly two decades of navigating educational leadership and politics.

Making Sense of Educational Leadership: Becoming an Educational Diplomat

Educational leadership is about being a visionary. It means putting the needs of students, caregivers, staff, and others in the organization ahead of our own needs. It means leading by example, building and nurturing relationships, and not only connecting the dots, so to speak, but actually creating, defining, and mapping the dots and then facilitating their connection. Not surprisingly, **communication** rises to the top of the most critical skill that a superintendent must work to master. *Spoiler alert: You will never master this skill.* But, working tirelessly to communicate to everyone, in the correct order, with the right message - balancing both intent and impact - will most certainly be part of the effective leader algorithm.

An effective school leader harnesses the necessary diplomatic skills to inspire, motivate, and genuinely value those within and outside the organization while

building alliances with the unlikeliest allies through meaningful, authentic, and personalized communication.

In his book Leadershift, Gobillot (2009) argues that the commitment a leader shows to the community that he serves is what creates his reputation. Reputation, rather than position, is what makes the leader strong and able to inspire and motivate others. "What creates a reputation is the commitment the leader has shown the community rather than the effectiveness by which they have made it work for their benefit" (Gobillot, 2009, p.83). When a reputable school superintendent works with community leaders and presents themself as someone who is trustworthy and who sincerely values the views and needs of others, meaningful relationships can be formed and sustained that will allow the school leader, as a representative of their community, to effectively position the school district for a prominent place on the public agenda.

According to the Mid-Decade Study prepared by the American Association of School Administrators (AASA), the superintendency is an increasingly "people"- type position, with superintendents saying that a lack of interpersonal communication skills is the factor most limiting their effectiveness. At the same time, they say that interpersonal communication is the most important factor in their effectiveness.

As it turns out, the sort of communication necessary for school leaders to truly be collaborative and simultaneously effective in their roles is persuasion, an arguably more tactical approach to garnering public support than a function of simple public relations. Persuasion, in this regard, demands specific skills beyond the leadership competencies expected of school leaders.

The six principles of persuasion, according to Sarah Cliffe, Professor Emeritus at Arizona State University, and consultant Robert Cialdini (2013), are:

1. **Liking** – If people feel warmly about you because you and they have things in common (or they think you like them), they're more persuadable.
2. **Reciprocity** – People tend to return favors. We are given serious persuasive power immediately after someone thanks us.
3. **Social Proof** – People tend to do what they see other people doing, especially people with whom they have a lot in common. When people see themselves as part of a larger group with a shared identity, they are willing to take steps they wouldn't for their individual interests.
4. **Commitment and Consistency** – People want to be consistent. Keep promises and take time to check on progress.
5. **Authority** – Most people defer to experts and those with power. The trick is to get others to promote your idea or your authority.
6. **Fear of Loss** – People fear what they might lose. Show them what they will lose if things don't change.

The Politics of Educational Leadership

It would seem obvious that having a vision for education as an aspiring, appointed, or elected superintendent would be a baseline job expectation, but regrettably I have encountered so many hopeful leaders who simply do not take the time to understand the pre-existing conditions of a school district or community and who, instead, rush to push forward their own agenda which can lead to resistance from the start.

In the political science world, there are two important terms of art that I have adopted in my work as an educational leader, and which have served me well for nearly two decades of district-level leadership: *Agenda-Setting* and *Windows of Opportunity*.

Agenda-setting determines ***what*** people pay attention to at any given time. This goes beyond a public meeting document that identifies what elected officials or school support organizations will discuss at their regular meetings. These are the bigger, broader topics that warrant public attention, framed by the narrative an effective leader can craft to define not only the problem to be solved but also the roadmap to getting there, doing so in a way that brings the entire community along for the ride.

Caution: There is a fine line here between persuasion and manipulation, so be careful. An educational diplomat can use honest communication and student-centered arguments of persuasion as a reliable and appropriate strategy.

Windows of Opportunity matter as much as the agenda itself because they signal ***when*** you want people to pay attention and take action. Okay, this does seem manipulative, but when grounded in trust, transparency, and a clear focus on student outcomes it becomes a form of educational altruism that builds genuine support.

Educational altruism reflects the responsibility school leaders hold on behalf of their communities. It requires vision, resolute leadership, and strong communication. As Fullen (2010) explained, it exists when leaders maintain a relentless focus on instructional improvement and align resources to support teaching and learning.

In today's complex political and community environments, gaining support for education requires skills beyond traditional leadership preparation. Politically literate leaders, those who understand how to influence, communicate, and build coalitions, are better positioned to advance an educational vision and keep students at the center of the work.

In public education, a broad range of stakeholders constitute local governance, including legislators, town or city officials, school superintendents, elected and appointed positions within

the community, and taxpayers, all of whom play an important role in garnering support for the educational agenda.

Beverly Parsons and Sharon Brumbaugh (2013) identify critical elements that are required to make collaboration work:

- **Start with numbers.** Build data into your plans to monitor the conditions of children and families, and tie that data to specific benchmarks of achievement.
- **Think systems, not programs.** Move beyond isolated initiatives and focus on creating coordinated systems that drive long-term improvement.
- **Build boats, not houses.** Design flexible, adaptive structures that can evolve as conditions and needs change.
- **Adopt collaboration as a way of life.** Commit to shared budgets, joint accountability, integrated professional development activities, and the creation of new vertical and horizontal relations with other government agencies.
- **Engage the public on its own terms.** Don't give the gobbledygook to the public. Develop strong, clear, two-way communication strategies.
- **Develop capacity.** Horizontal linkages with your agency peers are one thing. Vertical linkages up and down your different agencies are something else again, and much harder.
- **Create a critical mass of people who care.** You have to find the right people and invest in them. When you move on, you want this new way of thinking to survive.
- **Beg, borrow, and steal effective ideas.** Everything in public life is in the public domain. You're free to steal it. Do so shamelessly if you see something working.

- **Follow the money.** Talking about system reform is cheap and easy. Make sure that real budget resources are put behind the rhetoric.
- **Insist on results.** This is challenging work. If you're going to get into it, you have to be serious. Insist on results, assess progress, and report to the public.
- **Give ownership away.** There's truth to the axiom that, if we don't care who gets the credit, there's no limit to what we can accomplish. Give the credit away, and it will all come back to you.
- **Model the behavior you seek.** You can't expect your people to cooperate with other agencies if you refuse to give the time of day to your peers in local government.
- **Be a practical visionary.** Visionaries have to be practical, too. You have to have your feet on the ground. Develop an effective plan that delivers demonstrable results within a year or two.

It takes visionary leadership that is mindful of environmental factors and influences and, with clear direction and proper queuing, can truly move the educational agenda forward. That, in my experience, is the harmonious blend of education and politics, not the other kind of partisan and self-serving politics that simply gets in the way of getting anything done at all, and what can be a game-changer for a school superintendent.

When school superintendents can nurture a shared vision around education within their communities, without the deliberate manipulation of others, then community members will have a voice – a decided value that they have about the importance of education. How that value translates into community influence and action depends largely on the reputation and communication skills of the politically competent school leader.

Properly aligning an educational leader's defined purpose - *their why* - with the agenda they are setting as determined by their understanding of the needs and wants of the school community through personal interactions - *the what* - and thoughtfully placed within a timeline that considers the nuances of the community climate, culture, and political will - *the when* - is, to me, the equivalent of a brilliant symphony emerging from a cacophony of sounds. It is truly leadership from the podium, and it is a terrific segue to how I view the superintendent as conductor.

Leadership from the Podium: Soloists, Section Players, and Tutti Ensemble

I had the incredible opportunity to play trumpet in the New Hampshire Philharmonic Orchestra when I was a high school student, and it is a memory that not only shaped my studies in college as a music education major but also shaped my view of how people can work together. During my senior year of high school, I studied conducting with Robert C. Babb. It was as incredible as it was complex and frightening. I was learning to read an orchestral score where I had to make sense of multiple lines of music at the same time while providing visual direction with a baton in my right hand, all the while preparing to queue the entrances of various orchestral sections or soloists with my left hand, all without ever missing a beat. Literally.

There are plenty of texts that position the school or district leader as the conductor standing at the podium. And while I could easily include references and empirical data that one might find in a phenomenological dissertation that seeks to make sense of the model from an academic lens, I'm a practitioner at heart providing life experiences in a reflective chapter on what I view to be the critical political competencies for real world application for school and district leaders who want to lead impactful change. Change that stems from the nurturing of intentional and authentic relationships. Change that comes when you are fully present in every moment.

The score is the roadmap, the blueprint, the strategic plan. The principal musicians of each section are, well, your principals, and the sections themselves are your various teams, departments, or grades within your school or district. You, as superintendent, are holding the baton. You give the downbeats, sustain the fermatas, and set the tempo to provide leadership to the talented musicians who are looking to you for direction, but without a score, you're just waving your arms.

I will never forget my first summer as a school superintendent. I had been in the district as an Assistant Principal for three years, then as Principal at that same school for six years, and then took the helm as superintendent, a journey that would last another nine years. The first order of business was to understand every relationship within the organization. I vividly recall unrolling 10 feet of butcher paper across a conference room table and beginning to plot every organization, agency, partner, position, and school leader in their own dedicated oval on the page, and I enlisted others who knew the community well to help me connect the dots. Understanding the interrelationships, familial connections, interests, allies, enemies, assets, and threats to the organization - and to me as a leader - all got mapped. And they all got my full attention.

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Building Authentic Partnerships with Families and the Community

A Superintendent's Playbook for Trust, Visibility, and Buy-In

By Bill Runey

About the Author



Bill Runey is the Superintendent of the Dighton-Rehoboth Regional School District in Massachusetts, with a 38-year career spanning public and private sectors. He is the architect of the "DRiving Toward 2030" initiative, which centers on a visionary "Portrait of a Graduate" framework to guide student development. He has been recognized nationally for his leadership including being named one of Education Insider Magazine's Top 15 School Superintendents of 2026 and a District Administration Leaders of Distinction award winner. He is known for leveraging Artificial Intelligence and technology to streamline operations and strengthen communication, and is a frequent presenter on leadership, branding, and innovation in public education. Having previously led Attleboro High School and Bishop Feehan High School, he has led complex initiatives in facilities, programming, and districtwide improvement efforts. His approach is deeply personal, rooted in a family legacy of education and a commitment to igniting learning in every student.

This chapter is written from the perspective of a sitting superintendent who has learned, sometimes the hard way, that community trust is not built during moments of crisis, budget

season, or public controversy. It is built quietly, consistently, and intentionally over time.

What follows is not a theory of engagement, but a playbook shaped by lived experience: what it looks like to show up, to listen early, to tell the district's story honestly, and to build relationships strong enough to absorb inevitable challenges. My hope is that readers don't just recognize themselves in these pages, but leave with language, practices, and habits they can use immediately in their own communities.

It Starts With a Story (Not a Framework)

I learned one of the most important lessons of my administrative career long before I became a superintendent, not during a strategic planning retreat or a leadership seminar, but when the crackle of a walkie-talkie sent me urgently to the third floor.

It came during a moment that was serious, but ultimately manageable. A bomb threat had been written on a bathroom wall in the school. Law enforcement and the fire department responded quickly, and after speaking directly with both, it was clear there was no credible threat. Still, emotions were running high. Questions spread quickly. Rumors moved even faster. And families were watching closely to see how the school would respond.

At the time, the superintendent took a deliberately hands-off approach, not out of distance, but out of trust. After I had coordinated with police and fire departments, she made it clear: this was my building. In that moment, I felt both the confidence she had placed in me and the full weight of leadership that comes with it.

What struck me most wasn't the incident itself, but how the community reacted. Because relationships and communication were already in place, the situation didn't spiral out of control. It landed like a marble tossed into the ocean, not a bowling ball dropped into a bathtub…a lesson that has shaped how I approach leadership ever since.

In a bathtub, everything splashes. The noise is immediate. The walls are closed. There's no room for patience or perspective. In the ocean, the water absorbs the impact. Ripples still travel, but they don't overwhelm everything else.

That metaphor has stayed with me because it captures the essence of the superintendent's work. Our job isn't to prevent every problem. That's impossible. The real work is building a culture and a community strong enough to absorb difficult moments without losing trust or momentum.

And that work doesn't begin during a crisis.

It begins long before one ever appears.

The Core Idea (For Busy Leaders)

Here's the short version:

Authentic partnerships with families and the community are not "nice to have."

They are the foundation that makes everything else possible.

When trust is strong:

- Budgets are understood, even when they're tight
- Local votes and town decisions are grounded in understanding rather than reaction.
- Enrollment stabilizes because families believe in the district
- Staff feel supported rather than exposed
- Crisis response is grounded in credibility

When trust is weak, every issue feels heavier than it needs to be.

What's often misunderstood is how trust is built. It doesn't come from polished messaging or perfectly timed announcements. It comes from **consistent presence**, **honest communication**, and **visible follow-through**, over time.

That's the work of the ambassador.

The Ambassador Mindset: Presence Beats Messaging

One of the most effective phrases I use publicly is also one of the simplest:

"These are the community's schools."

That sentence reframes the conversation immediately. It shifts the focus away from "the district" as a system and toward shared ownership. It signals respect for the community's investment, not just financial, but emotional and civic. And it reminds leaders that our role is stewardship, not entitlement.

When people feel ownership, their posture changes. They ask better questions. They listen more carefully. They're more willing to wrestle with complexity. And when challenges arise, they're more likely to protect the schools rather than attack them.

From Transactional to Relational Leadership

Transactional leadership sounds like:

- "Here's what we're doing."
- "Here's what we've decided."
- "Here's why you should support it."

Relational leadership sounds like:

- "Here's what we're seeing."
- "Here are the challenges."
- "Here's how we can move forward together."

That difference may seem subtle, but it fundamentally changes how communities engage. One implies compliance. The other invites collaboration.

Playbook: Language You Can Use Immediately

If you want to reinforce shared ownership, try language like:

- "Our schools belong to this community, and our responsibility is to earn and keep that trust."
- "We may not all agree on the solution, but we owe each other an honest process."

- "My commitment is transparency, especially when the answers are complicated."

Small shifts in language often produce outsized shifts in tone.

Visibility Is Not Optics — It's Strategy

Some superintendents hesitate to lean into visibility. They worry it will be misinterpreted as self-promotion or political maneuvering. I understand that instinct. But I've learned the opposite is true.

Visibility is not about ego. It's about access.

When families and community members see you consistently, at school events, concerts, athletic games, PTO/PTSA meetings, town events like a Founder's Day Fair, Select Board meetings, or other informal gatherings, they stop guessing who you are. They understand your tone. They know how you respond under pressure. And they feel comfortable asking questions directly instead of speculating online.

Visibility also disrupts misinformation. In a vacuum, rumors thrive. When leadership is present and recognizable, people have a reference point: *That doesn't sound like how he leads. I've seen how he handles things.*

What Visibility Looks Like in Practice

Visibility doesn't require speeches or spotlights. It requires consistency.

For me, that means:

- Informal school visits without an agenda
- Attending student performances and athletic events without needing to speak
- Showing up to PTO/PTSA meetings to listen
- Staying after meetings so conversations can happen organically

The goal isn't performance.

The goal is familiarity.

Playbook: Be Visible Without Burning Out

You don't need to attend everything. Try this instead:

- Pick **two standing events per month** you always attend
- Rotate **one school visit per week**
- Create **one informal listening opportunity per quarter**

Consistency builds trust. Volume leads to burnout.

How Our Strategic Plan Became a Trust Tool

In my district, ***DRiving Toward 2030*** **(DT2030)**, our strategic plan, became more than a roadmap. It became a trust-building mechanism.

DT2030 is anchored in three principles:

- Empower
- Ignite
- Shape

What makes these words powerful is that they're actionable. They translate directly into how a district engages families and the community.

Empower: Ownership Creates Buy-In

Empowerment is often confused with consensus-building. It isn't.

Empowerment is about credibility.

People don't need to agree with every outcome. They do need to believe the process was honest, inclusive, and transparent.

During **DT2030**, we intentionally:

- Held listening sessions before drafting solutions
- Asked what the community wanted to preserve, not just what it wanted to change
- Shared survey results publicly, even when the feedback was uncomfortable
- Explained financial, staffing, and enrollment constraints plainly

Most importantly, we closed the loop. We didn't just say, "Thanks for the feedback." We said, "Here's what we heard, and here's how it shaped our direction."

That follow-through is what turns participation into trust.

Playbook: What Empowerment Looks Like on the Ground

Before finalizing a major decision, ask yourself:

- Did people have input early enough to matter?
- Can they see where their feedback influenced outcomes?
- Would someone who disagrees still say the process was fair?

If the answer is yes, you're empowering—even without consensus.

Ignite: Positivity Is a Leadership Tool

Most districts don't lack good news.

They lack consistent storytelling.

When left untold, positive work disappears. When left unbalanced, negative narratives dominate. That's why we made a conscious decision to flood the zone with good news.

We consistently share:

- Student achievement and leadership
- Innovative teaching and learning
- Grants and partnerships
- Our **DT2030** strategic plan is action, not just on paper

We use a consistent communication platform to push stories through social media and mirror them on our website. We issue frequent press releases, not because everything is headline-worthy, but because repetition builds familiarity, and familiarity builds trust.

School Spotlight Meetings: A Simple Shift With Big Impact

One of the most effective engagement strategies we introduced was School Spotlight Meetings at School Committee meetings.

Once a month, a school brings students, staff, and leaders to showcase their work.

The impact was immediate:

- Families showed up to support their children
- School Committee members saw what's in our classrooms, not just reports
- Students felt celebrated
- It connected School Committee members more directly to the daily work happening in our schools.

That single shift did more to build goodwill than any slideshow ever could.

Playbook: Create One "Joy Anchor"

Identify one recurring, public moment where:

- Students are the center
- Staff are celebrated
- Families are invited in

Protect it on the calendar.

Joy is not fluff, it's infrastructure.

Shape: Preparing the Community Before the Vote

Large initiatives fail when leaders wait too long to explain the "why."

Facilities planning is a clear example. Building projects, especially those involving state-aided processes, are complex and expensive. If the first time the community hears about them is close to a vote, skepticism is inevitable.

Instead, we:

- Hosted open houses to walk the community through the building, the need, and the options
- Created a dedicated project website with meeting agendas, minutes, timelines, and reference materials
- Explained the process, timeline, and constraints
- Shared resources and answered questions early

By the time decisions were needed, people weren't shocked. They were informed.

Playbook: The One-Year Rule

If something will eventually require a vote or major support:

- Start telling the story **one year earlier** than feels necessary

- Repeat it calmly and consistently
- Assume people need to hear it more than once

Preparation builds trust. Surprise erodes it.

Branding Without Spin

Branding in public education can feel uncomfortable. It shouldn't.

Brand isn't a logo. It's ***identity.***

If leaders don't define what their district stands for, others will do it for them, and not always accurately.

In our case, that clarity mattered. We are a regional school district funded by two separate towns, and when I arrived, the relationship between those communities and the district was strained. There was pride in individual towns, but not always a shared sense of identity or ownership in the schools we operate together.

#WeAreDR emerged as more than a slogan. It became ***words we live by*** — a way to reinforce that we are one district serving two communities, and that how we treat people, how we communicate, and how we show up under pressure matters. Over time, it helped shift the conversation from *"your schools" and "our town"* to *"our schools and our shared responsibility."*

A Simple Gesture That Builds Belonging

I dress as our high school's Falcon mascot at elementary schools.

It's fun. It's memorable. And it sends a simple message: *This is one district. This is your future. You belong here.*

Culture is built through moments like that.

Engagement in a World of Choice

Families today have real options, especially at the high school level. Ignoring that reality doesn't protect enrollment. Engaging it thoughtfully does.

We focus on building a **pipeline of connection**, not a one-time recruitment push:

- Green & Gold open houses
- Middle school field trips
- High school roadshows featuring student voices

Students listen to students. Families trust authenticity.

Community Engagement *Is* Fiscal Leadership

This is a hard-earned lesson:

Budget season reveals the relationships you built—or didn't build—the rest of the year.

Residents vote. Trust shapes how they engage, question, and ultimately support public education.

Clear, plain-language communication about finances, shared early and often, makes difficult conversations possible. It doesn't guarantee agreement, but it earns respect.

One of the smartest decisions our School Committee made was honoring my request to invest in a full-time grantwriter. That role paid for itself many times over and reinforced our commitment to stewarding the community's shared investment responsibly.

Playbook: Budget Language That Builds Trust

When discussing finances, try framing it this way:

- "Here's what's fixed."
- "Here's what's changing."

- “Here’s what we can control.”
- “Here’s what we can’t, and why.”

Clarity lowers the temperature.

Serving Families Beyond the Classroom

What happens outside of school matters just as much as what happens inside it.

When districts connect families to resources, food support, community services, local partnerships, it builds trust faster than any communication strategy.

It also builds credibility. Families who feel supported are far more likely to assume good intent when challenges arise.

The Pattern of Trust

Trust grows through a predictable pattern: Share good news consistently

- Build pride
- Increase engagement
- Strengthen trust
- Make hard conversations easier
- Repeat

This isn’t about controlling the narrative.

It’s about telling the truth often enough that it sticks.

A Superintendent’s Monday Morning Playbook

If you want to act immediately:

- Be visibly present every week
- Create one recurring spotlight moment
- Audit how often you share good news
- Build one pipeline experience
- Explain finances before budget season
- Invest in communication capacity
- Build trust long before you need it

Why This Work Matters

The ambassador role isn't something separate from leadership. It *is* the work.

If you don't build trust ahead of time, every issue feels bigger than it needs to be. It's a bowling ball dropped into a bathtub - loud, messy, and impossible to contain.

But when relationships are strong -when people know you, understand your intent, and have seen you show up - the same issue lands differently. It's a pebble in the ocean. The ripples are there, but the water has depth.

That depth doesn't appear overnight. It's built by being present, telling the truth, and doing the relational work long before it's tested.

When families trust schools, they partner.

When communities believe in districts, they invest.

When students feel pride, they stay.

That's what allows a district to respond with perspective instead of panic, and to keep moving forward together.

Because at the end of the day, ***these are the community's schools***. And leadership means making sure they're strong enough to absorb whatever comes next.

PART II

THE CULTIVATOR: BUILDING PEOPLE & CULTURE

Empowered and Resilient Leadership Teams

How clarity, autonomy, humility, and celebration create teams that thrive, especially under pressure

By Chris Shearer

About the Author



Chris Shearer serves as the Principal of Johns Creek High School in Georgia, where he has become a leading voice for authentic, modern school leadership. Throughout his tenure within the Fulton County Schools system, Shearer has championed a philosophy he calls "Gladiator Strong," a cultural framework that emphasizes integrity, service, and excellence. His leadership style is built upon four core pillars: transparency, authenticity, clear communication, and accessibility. Unlike traditional administrative models that can feel distant, Shearer prioritizes being a visible and active presence in the hallways and at community events, believing that the heart of education lies in the daily interactions between leadership and the student body. He is known for his willingness to challenge the status quo, frequently encouraging his staff and students to ask difficult questions and rethink traditional instructional methods to better serve a diverse, modern learner.

Introduction

Empowered and resilient leadership teams don't emerge by accident; they are intentionally built through a sustained commitment to clarity, trust, and growth. In environments defined by complexity and constant change, teams that withstand pressure and respond with creativity have an unmistakable profile: they align around vision, learn from adversity, lead with courage, and celebrate progress often. These teams are not perfect. But they are present. They are responsive. They are learning. They are growing.

This chapter presents nine practical principles for developing empowered, resilient teams:

1. Clarify vision
2. Identify past challenges
3. Lead by imperfect example
4. Provide autonomy and empower decision-making
5. Model self-reflection
6. Allow the team to fail forward and grow from mistakes
7. Support them
8. Show gratitude, appreciation, and compassion
9. Celebrate

Each principle stands alone and reinforces the others. Collectively, they form a cycle of clarity → action → learning → support → renewal—a rhythm that equips teams to show up with courage when the stakes are high, and the path is uncertain.

1) Clarify Vision: A Linchpin in Ambiguity

What it is: Vision is the concise articulation of where the team is headed and why it matters. It is the shared direction that undergirds decisions, behavior, and priorities.

Why it matters: In dynamic environments, ambiguity can grow. Without clarity, teams default to being overly cautious or can become disparate. Vision provides a common lens that reduces noise and builds alignment.

How to do it well:

- **Draft a directional statement** that is brief enough to remember and strong enough to guide action. *Example:* "We are committed to creating a collaborative environment that develops all students into critical thinkers, life-long learners and productive citizens who aspire to the values of integrity, service, and excellence."
- **Connect the vision to outcomes**: identify 3-5 key metrics or qualitative indicators that reflect progress (e.g., student growth targets, staff retention, stakeholder satisfaction).
- **Translate vision into behaviors**: for each indicator, define concrete actions that reflect the vision in daily practice.
  Example Behaviors: "Leaders visit classrooms weekly; teams publish professional learning community data dives; students co-create learning goals."

Leader scripts:

- *Kickoff framing:* "Here's our vision in a sentence. Here's how we'll know we're living it. Here's what it looks like today in our daily behaviors."
- *Decision check:* "Which option best advances our vision while honoring our values? If neither, what would?"

Pitfalls to avoid:

- *Over-inflated vision statements* that sound good but don't guide action. Is the vision actionable?
- *Vision drift* - when short-term pressures overwrite long-term direction. Counter with weekly alignment moments.

Reflection prompts:

- "Could a new team member summarize our vision and know how it changes their day?"
- "What do we stop doing because it is off vision, even if it's urgent?"

2) Identify Past Challenges: Not about Blame, It's About Learning to Grow

What it is: A structured review of prior obstacles (operational, human, cultural) designed to extract insight without shaming individuals or re-litigating old conflicts.

Why it matters: Resilience grows when teams discover their patterns - the ability to spot recurring dynamics (e.g., bottlenecks, communication gaps) and design smarter processes.

A simple retrospective framework:

1. **Facts:** What happened? (key events, timelines, decisions)
2. **Feelings:** How did the team experience it? (stressors, surprises)
3. **Findings:** What did we learn? (what to repeat, what to retire)
4. **Forward:** What will we change next time? (policies, checkpoints, owners, deadlines)

Practices to normalize learning:

- **Make retrospectives routine** (end of every project or quarter).
- **Be blameless**: focus on systems and moments, not people.

- **Share lessons learned** with one page of actions and owners.

Leader scripts:

- "We are not here to assign fault; we are here to support learning."
- "Let's discover the insights now, so our future selves don't pay for what we already know."

Pitfalls:

- *Skipping the emotional layer:* ignoring team feelings reduces trust and stalls learning.
- *Only reviewing failures:* including successes to solidify repeatable wins.

Reflection prompts:

- "Which single process change would have prevented 50% of the pain last cycle?"
- "What did we do well that we almost missed because we were focused on the hard parts?"

3) Lead by Imperfect Example: Courage, not Perfection

What it is: Leaders model vulnerability in public. They make reasoned decisions, own their missteps, and demonstrate how to recover, refine, and recommit.

Why it matters: Teams imitate what leaders reward and reveal. When leaders practice "imperfect example," they signal that experimentation, iteration, and growth are welcome.

Practices that make vulnerability safe:

- **Think out loud:** walk through your reasoning and trade-offs.

- **Name uncertainty:** this is an idea, assess and adjust when needed
- **Own the miss quickly:** admit when things miss the target, then prepare to develop new ways to move forward
- **Invite dissent:** allow room for the team to give their input, ask them what you are missing

A micro-habit: The 1–2–1 cadence

- **1 admission**: share a mistake and what you learned.
- **2 appreciations**: highlight others' efforts or improvements.
- **1 ask**: request input or a perspective you're missing.

Leader scripts:

- "I left out an important person; that's on me. Here's how we pivot."
- "I'm testing an informal walkthrough process; please challenge it and tell me where it falls short."

Pitfalls:

- *Performative vulnerability* - sharing only safe admissions or turning vulnerability into a brand.
- *Decision paralysis* - confusing humility with indecision. Vulnerability lives inside decisive action.

Reflection prompts:

- "Where can I show my learning curve this week without compromising safety or trust?"
- "What fear keeps me from modeling imperfection, and what small step reduces that fear?"

4) Provide Autonomy & Empower Decision-Making: Trust as a Practice

What it is: Leaders distribute authority, set clear guardrails, and enable teams to design solutions and make decisions closer to the work. A guiding thought here is that it is not the leader's job to do the work of those on their team. Do not fall into the micromanagement trap.

Why it matters: Autonomy accelerates speed, strengthens ownership, and brings forth innovations that centralized decision-making often misses.

A practical empowerment model: DDD (Define–Delegate–Decide)

- **Define guardrails:** outcomes, constraints, timelines, and non-negotiables.
- **Delegate ownership:** assign decision-rights explicitly (who decides, who advises, who informs).
- **Decide together:** agree on decision criteria (impact on stakeholders, feasibility, alignment with vision).

Tool that helps:

- **Decision organizer:** brief records of choices, rationale, data sources, and revisit date.

Leader scripts:

- "You own the decision within these guardrails. I'll advise if asked; you inform me of major milestones."
- "If the choice is between speed and perfection, choose speed with a fast feedback loop."

Pitfalls:

- *Autonomy without real support* - delegating without resources or time.

- *Shadow vetoes* - leaders override decisions without prior guardrails, undermining trust. Avoid by agreeing on stop conditions upfront.

Reflection prompts:

- "Which decision can I push closer to work this week?"
- "Do people know when I expect to be consulted?"

5) Model Self-Reflection: The Past is Your Teacher

What it is: Leaders practice routine self-assessment on decisions, behaviors, and effects, and openly share how reflection changes their actions.

Why it matters: Teams mirror leaders. When reflection is visible, it normalizes feedback, learning, and continuous improvement.

A simple weekly reflection:

- **What worked?** (keep/scale)
- **What faltered?** (adjust/ask support)
- **What did I notice from the team?** (energy, friction, ideas)
- **What will I change next week?** (one behavior, one habit, one message)

Turning reflection into practice:

- **Public commitments:** "This week, I'm shortening meetings by 10 minutes and closing with clear actions."
- **Feedback loops:** invite structured feedback monthly and summarize publicly: "Here's what I heard and what I'll change."

Leader scripts:

- "My intent was X; the impact was Y. I'm adjusting by doing Z."
- "I need perspective from those closest to the work: what effect did my decision have?"

Pitfalls:

- *Reflection without change:* it's inauthentic.
- *Confessional overload:* share enough to create learning, not so much that it burdens the team.

Reflection prompts:

- "What behavior of mine most shapes the team's day, for better or worse?"
- "What single shift would make others' work easier next week?"

6) Allow the Team to Fail Forward: Mistakes as Momentum

What it is: Teams are encouraged to take smart risks, run pilots, and treat failures as iterative data. Leaders design recovery processes and learning loops.

Why it matters: Innovation requires experimentation. Resilience grows when teams practice structured curiosity and can safely course correct.

Designing fail-forward systems:

- **Pilot with purpose:** small scope, short timeline, clear metrics.
- **Set "safe-to-try" rules:** If a pilot is reversible, low-cost, and aligned with vision, default to yes.
- **Rapid review:** after 2–4 weeks, assess what to keep, adjust, or retire.

- **Archive learnings:** take note of what's been tried to prevent repeated mistakes and encourage reuse.

Leader scripts:

- "This is a pilot; we expect imperfection. Let's track two metrics that matter and one surprise worth exploring."
- "If we fail, we'll fail small, learn fast, and roll forward with better insight."

Pitfalls:

- *Undefined pilots* that drift into full-scale bets.
- *Punitive responses to misses* that chill experimentation. Focus feedback on the process, not the person.

Reflection prompts:

- "Where is our risk appetite too low for the outcomes we seek?"
- "Which small experiment could unlock a disproportionate gain?"

7) Support Them: Presence, Resources, and Psychological Safety

What it is: Support is both tangible (time, tools, training, coverage) and relational (presence, listening, advocacy). It ensures autonomy isn't isolation.

Why it matters: Teams only take risks if they believe their leaders have their back. Support grows trust, strengthens execution, and reduces burnout.

Support strategies:

- **Resource audits:** quarterly review of workload, tools, and bottlenecks; adjust or reassign.

- **Coverage plans:** protect time for deep work and learning (e.g., coverage for classroom observations and stakeholder meetings).
- **Listening:** open door policy; regular pulse checks
- **Coaching and mentoring:** offer role-specific coaching to accelerate confidence.

Leader scripts:

- "What do you need to do your best work and what's getting in the way?"
- "Are there things I can remove this week, or do for you? Which one matters most?"

Pitfalls:

- *Support theater:* offer soothing words without removing barriers.
- *Over-supporting:* excessive hand-holding that reduces autonomy and accountability. Tune to need, not anxiety.

Reflection prompts:

- "Does your calendar reflect stated priorities?"
- "Where can I remove friction that impacts many, not just a few?"

8) Show Gratitude, Appreciation, and Compassion: Fuel for Their Work, Sustain Their Effort

What it is: Intentional recognition of effort and progress. Leaders value people for both outcomes and the way they pursue them.

Why it matters: Appreciation replenishes energy and strengthens belonging. Compassion creates space for life's realities while maintaining high standards aligned with vision.

Meaningful recognition rhythms:

- **Micro-thanks:** weekly, handwritten notes, quick messages, shout-outs.
- **Spotlights:** weekly highlights of specific behaviors that align with vision.
- **Compassionate flexibility:** respond to personal challenges with adjustments, coverage, phased timelines, or referral to supports.
- **Storytelling:** share narratives of perseverance and learning; diversify who gets recognized.

Leader scripts:

- "I noticed the care you brought to the stakeholder meeting; your preparation showed, and it built trust."
- "You're carrying a lot right now. Let's adjust scope for two weeks and check again then."

Pitfalls:

- *Generic praise* ("great job!") that doesn't connect to behaviors or impact.
- *Uneven appreciation* that quietly favors visible roles; zoom out and see the entire forest, not just a few trees.

Reflection prompts:

- "Whose contribution has mattered but gone unrecognized?"
- "How does my gratitude map to our values and vision in specific terms?"

9) Celebrate: Mark Progress, Build Memory, Create Joy

What it is: Intentional celebration of milestones: wins, improvements, completed experiments, hard-fought lessons that strengthen identity and cohesion.

Why it matters: Celebration creates positive emotional memory. It turns progress into a shared story, fuels motivation, and signals that the journey is worth it.

Celebration ideas:

- **Progress walks:** monthly huddles: three wins, one learning, one growth opportunity.
- **Travelling statue:** a weekly opportunity for the staff to recognize one another. Share the reason why the staff member received the statue with the entire school.
- **Student or stakeholder voice:** invite brief testimonials to connect work to impact.
- **Friday Feels:** monthly form where staff can recognize a colleague who helped them or is doing a great job that is going unnoticed. Share these with the staff via email on Friday morning on Friday morning in an email.

Leader scripts:

- "We said we would do it and we did. Here's why it matters, and here's what's next."
- "The effort deserves a moment. Let's mark it together."

Pitfalls:

- *Celebration only for perfect wins* - include near-misses and endurance moments.
- *Celebration for Celebration's Sake* - empty gestures without meaning. Tie celebration to impact and learning.

Reflection prompts:

- "What are we proud of this month that we can name and share?"

- "How do we celebrate progress in ways that feel authentic to our culture?"

Integrating the Nine: A Practical Operating Rhythm

Resilient, empowered teams benefit from a predictable cadence:

Weekly

- *Vision check-in:* one decision or priority aligned with vision.
- *Wins & misses:* what worked, what needs adjustment.
- *Support scan:* identify and remove one blocker.
- *Micro-celebration:* one specific shout-out.

Monthly

- *Retrospective:* blameless review of one initiative.
- *Experiment planning:* two safe-to-try pilots with metrics.
- *Recognition & renewal:* spotlight narratives; set one growth focus.

Quarterly

- *Vision + metrics review:* assess progress, recalibrate targets, refine behaviors.
- *Resource audit:* workload, tools, coverage; adjust.
- *Pulse check:* feedback synthesis and response plan.

Annual

- *Stories of the year:* capture the year's narratives of growth.
- *Strategy refresh:* revise vision, outcomes, and guardrails.

- *Celebration ceremony:* honor contributions and learning.

The Human Layer: Values, Boundaries, and Energy

Empowerment and resilience are not merely structural; they are human. Leaders must attend to the emotional currents of a team: hope, disappointment, fatigue, pride. Structures help, but *presence* heals. Compassion stabilizes. Boundaries protect. Celebration renews.

Three human practices:

- **Check-ins with substance:** start meetings with a one-question pulse (e.g., "Tell me something good.").
- **Boundaries with clarity:** define response expectations, honor them publicly.
- **Energy renewal:** normalize recovery cycles post-crisis (lighter weeks, reduced meeting load) and protect them.

The Courage to Build, The Grace to Learn

Empowered, resilient leadership teams are not assembled; they are formed through the daily practice of clarity, humility, and care. The nine principles in this chapter are not slogans; they are operational choices: choosing to frame vision as behavior, to build learning from challenge, to lead with imperfect courage, to share authority, to reflect publicly, to fail forward, to support generously, to appreciate deeply, and to celebrate with meaning.

There will be days when the work feels heavy, when decisions are complex and outcomes uncertain. On those days, remember that resilience is not a trait; it's a rhythm, and you can restart the rhythm anytime: clarify, act, learn, support, celebrate. Teams that master this rhythm do more than endure; they create futures worth stepping into.

Hidden in Plain Sight

Cultivating the Talent Already in Our Schools

By Dr. Keisha Scarlett

About the Author



Dr. Keisha Scarlett is a systems strategist, executive coach, and founder of Rubescent, a systems strategy consultancy. A former urban superintendent and principal, she spent more than two decades leading in Seattle Public Schools before serving as Superintendent of St. Louis Public Schools. She currently serves as Superintendent in Residence at the University of Washington. Her work focuses on building ecosystems that develop leaders from within the communities they serve.

Where it all began

In late August 2012, I stood near the back of the South Shore PK-8 gym watching nearly 250 new teacher recruits settle in for Seattle Public Schools' New Teacher Orientation. I was the principal of the school hosting the event, and I was curious to see who the district had hired.

I scanned the room slowly.

There were very few teachers of color in the audience. Not a single African American teacher among the new recruits.

The teaching profession in this country is largely led by white women, and many of them do extraordinary work every day for our most diverse students. I knew that. But standing in that gym, I felt a deep unease I couldn't shake. Something was wrong, and I needed to name it.

When I brought it up to district staff, the answer came quickly: there just weren't many applicants of color.

That answer stopped me cold.

Because just outside that meeting room, in schools across Southeast Seattle, people were holding the system together every day. Instructional assistants. Family support workers. Community partners. People who knew our students by name, who understood the rhythms of our neighborhoods, who had grown up in these same zip codes. Many of them were Black and other educators of color.

They weren't certified teachers. But they were already doing the work.

And in the high schools nearby, I could see students who, with the right encouragement and a clear path forward, would become extraordinary teachers for the very communities that raised them.

I knew this because I had been one of them.

I majored in Chemistry and Mathematics as an undergraduate with every intention of going to medical school. I had the grades, the path, the plan. But the only thing I actually wanted to do was teach in the community that raised me. Once I made that choice, I never looked back. Fourteen years later I was the principal of a school in Rainier Beach, the neighborhood where my parents still lived and where I owned a home. I had done exactly what I believed other young people and adults from Southeast Seattle wanted to do.

The difference was that nobody had designed a path for them to follow.

The talent wasn't missing. It was hidden in plain sight.

The Proposal Nobody Was Ready For

That fall, I wrote a proposal I called the Southeast Seattle Homegrown Teacher Project. The idea was straightforward: recruit students from Rainier Beach High School, support them through teacher preparation, and return them to Seattle classrooms. I connected the concept to the Call Me MISTER program I'd learned about at Clemson that summer, a model that recruited Black men into teaching by identifying them in high school and walking with them all the way through certification.

My version would do the same for Southeast Seattle students of any background who wanted to teach in the communities where they grew up.

I brought the proposal to Tom Stritikus, then Dean of the University of Washington College of Education, through my work with the UW College of Education Ambassadors. Tom understood what I was trying to build. The problem was structural. UW did not have an undergraduate teacher preparation program that could house it.

The proposal was tabled.

I moved on. The idea stayed with me.

The Idea That Wouldn't Stay Quiet

Three years later I was a Principal Leadership Coach and had just been admitted to UW's Leadership for Learning doctoral program. I had lunch with Dr. Deana Sands, the new Dean of the College of Education at Seattle University. She shared her vision for the college and their teacher prep program. I told her about the proposal. She asked me to send it.

Her response came fast. She wanted me to come lead the program and fold it into my doctoral research.

I gave it real thought. In hindsight, it is one of those decisions that looks different with time. I had just been accepted into the UW Leadership for Learning doctoral program and had made a commitment I intended to keep. I passed on the offer. Dr. Sands was ready. I was the one who wasn't.

The proposal sat quiet again.

By 2016 I had moved into a new role as Director of Professional Growth and Educator Support in Seattle Public Schools' Human Resources division. One afternoon I was meeting with Lucas Dobbs, a consulting teacher who worked closely with secondary educators. He was frustrated, carrying the same weight I'd been carrying for years. The teacher pipeline wasn't diverse. Representation wasn't improving. The same external recruitment strategies kept producing the same results.

I mentioned a proposal I'd written years earlier.

Lucas came back the next morning. 'Boss Lady,' he said, 'we need to do something with this.'

I was promoted shortly after into the Executive Director of Organizational Development role, which pulled me into new responsibilities before we'd built any real momentum on the idea. But Lucas kept coming back to it. Every time I saw him, he'd ask where things stood.

A Saturday, a Mentor, and a Yes

November 2017. I was at the annual HBCU and Black College Fair at Seattle Central College on a Saturday afternoon. Moving through the crowd, I ran into Dr. Sheila Edwards Lange, the president of Seattle Central College, who had been a mentor for years.

I asked her a simple question: 'Dr. Sheila, do you want an urban teacher preparation program here at Seattle Central?'

She didn't hesitate. 'Yes. We already have an early childhood education program. I'd love to see it expand to prepare and certify teachers.'

That was the moment.

The idea was five years old by then. What was different was that the right person, with the right institutional authority and genuine appetite for it, said yes on the same day I happened to ask.

In January 2018, I pulled together a small group by email: Dr. Edwards Lange, longtime Seattle Central professor Dr. Daudi Abe, City of Seattle education director Dwane Chappelle, and Lucas Dobbs. We met in March. Dr. Abe tells it best. He was so excited about the meeting that he showed up a full month early.

By April 2018 we had a formal proposal addressed to Dr. Edwards Lange from a cross-sector team that included Seattle Public Schools, Seattle Central College, and the City of Seattle. The pathway we designed moved students from high school to paraprofessional employment to an associate's degree at Seattle Central to teaching certification, with financial support at every stage so cost would not be the reason someone stopped.

Getting three institutions to yes required more than shared interest. It required each partner to restructure something. Seattle Central had to pursue new accreditation and repurpose faculty. Seattle Public Schools had to align its existing classified to certificated program within the new pathway. The City of Seattle had to connect the Seattle Promise scholarship, which

provides two free years of college for every SPS graduate, to the pipeline, with additional levy funds allocated in later years to sustain it. Nobody gave up nothing <anything>. That's what made it real.

Superintendent Larry Nyland, the Mayor's office, and Dr. Edwards Lange all gave their support. The Academy for Rising Educators launched in the summer of 2019.

What Cultivation Actually Looks Like

The Academy expanded to include existing instructional assistants, many working in special education and multilingual programs, giving them a funded path to teaching certification in the areas where students needed them most.

When the first cohort launched in 2019, my eldest daughter Deja joined as a community participant. The following year, my younger daughter Dani joined the second cohort as a 2020 high school graduate.

Dani represents the original vision exactly as I drew it up in 2012. A recent, 2020 high school graduate from Seattle Public Schools, she entered the program that same year and became a teaching fellow at a public charter school the same year. Dani earned her BA in Early Childhood Education in 2024, and is now a first grade teacher and grade level team lead in a diverse school community. In the 2026-2027 school year, she returns to continue into the master's program.

In 2025, Deja and other students from cohort one completed their Master's in Teaching at the University of Washington. She graduated from the program I had written a proposal for in 2012, in the back of a school gym, seven years before the program existed.

In 2022, the University of Washington returned as a programmatic partner with financial resources, making ARE a barrier-free teacher preparation program. The institution that

could not house the idea in 2012 eventually joined what the idea built.

I did not design the program with Deja and Dani in mind. But watching them complete it made something clear that I had been circling for years. The systems we build are rarely for the people we imagine when we design them. They are for the people already present, waiting for a path that fits. Sometimes that person turns out to be your own child.

The Lesson

I spent years watching districts pour resources into external recruitment while the people already inside their buildings as staff and community partners, people who loved these communities, who understood these students, who wanted to stay and build something, were treated as support staff rather than educators in formation.

Your pipeline isn't empty. Your systems are designed to make talent invisible.

Most pipeline problems are actually design problems. Districts look for teachers in the same places they've always looked, national recruitment fairs, partner universities, out-of-state pipelines, and then wonder why the workforce doesn't reflect the communities it serves. The answer is usually sitting in the front office, coaching a sports team, running a classroom when the teacher is out, or translating for a family at a school event.

Between 2012 and 2019, the idea stayed the same. I changed. I stopped trying to convince one institution at a time and built the coalition for the idea to find its home.

Cultivation is a long game. It requires leaders who see potential before credentials confirm it, who build pathways instead of waiting for pipelines to fill on their own, and who understand that the most important talent decisions happen in the small moments when you decide to invest in someone who is already there.

What This Means for You

Who in your system is already doing the work of teaching without the title? Who, with a clear pathway and real financial support, would stay and serve the community they came from? The answer is probably already in your buildings and surrounding communities. First, you have to decide to see them.

Help Them Grow or Help Them Go

By Dr. Leslie Sparacello

About the Author



Dr. Leslie Sparacello is the Superintendent of Cedars International Academy, a Texas public charter school serving PK3–12 students. With more than 30 years of experience in public education, she is known for driving systemwide improvement and building high-performing schools. Under her leadership, Cedars achieved a full academic turnaround, improving from a D to an A rating across all TEA accountability domains while strengthening enrollment, financial stability, and college and career readiness outcomes. She has served as a superintendent, principal, and district leader across multiple Texas systems, consistently delivering measurable gains in student achievement and organizational performance. Dr. Sparacello holds a doctorate in educational leadership and is committed to expanding access to high-quality learning experiences for all students.

Introduction

If you ask any educational leader about today's biggest challenge in schools, without a doubt you will hear the same answer: the shortage of quality teachers. Our current reality is that many teachers are reaching retirement age, and the number entering the profession is simply not keeping up with demand. Add to this the continued pressure to do more with less, and you will find leaders who are stuck between a rock and a hard place. On one hand, they need an adult in the classroom. On the other, they cannot place just anyone in a room full of children who need more support than ever before.

The only real answer to this question is a quality teacher in every classroom, but across the nation leaders are quietly wrestling with the question, "Is imperfect instruction better than no instruction?" Trying to answer this question can lead us to hesitate both to hire and to fire. We care about quality, but we also require stability. And, while we always try to hire the best teachers possible, those teachers are hard to find and occasionally even those we are able to hire do not work out as we had hoped. Since it is our responsibility as leaders to ensure that there is a quality educator in every classroom, we must employ strategies to "Help them grow.....or help them go".

The Hiring Challenge

Hiring is a long, arduous process that takes a great deal of time and pulls attention away from instruction. Training new employees is a long, arduous process that pulls valuable resources away from direct instruction and adds costs to the budget. Thus, bad hires are some of the most expensive mistakes leadership can make in both funding and time (which is ultimately funding). Changes and turnover caused by bad hires create additional disruption in instruction; furthermore, those same bad hires can lock us into individuals that might actually "harm" instruction directly. To complicate matters, the longer shortages exist, the more dangerous this compromise becomes. Temporary decisions slowly become cultural

expectations. Tolerance replaces improvement. Avoiding the conversation doesn't prevent vacancies, it just delays them until the worst possible moment.

The best advice I can give any administrator is to use the E-Harmony 29 points of compatibility in hiring. Your campus has a culture. Your student demographic has specific needs. Your organization has a leadership capacity level. All of these factors will contribute to the type of teacher you need to fill your vacancies. It is the leader's job to ensure that when they hire, they are taking all of these factors into consideration.

Research consistently shows that high teacher turnover lowers student achievement, especially in high-needs schools where instructional continuity matters most. After all, the best defence is always a good offense! Thus, step number one is about ensuring you have a solid process for hiring.

To ensure a strong hiring process, ask yourself the following questions:

- What are the specific instructional and behavioural needs of our students right now and does this candidate have demonstrated success with students like ours?
- What does our culture truly require to thrive here: structure, urgency, flexibility, collaboration and does this person naturally operate that way?
- Are we hiring someone who aligns with our non-negotiables, or someone we hope will adapt to them later?
- What level of coaching does this candidate realistically need and do we currently have the leadership capacity to provide it?
- If this teacher struggles, do we have the time, systems, and stamina to grow them or are we setting ourselves up for frustration?

- Does this candidate strengthen our strongest teachers or will our strongest teachers feel the weight of compensating for them?
- Are we filling a vacancy or building the team our students deserve?

The Retention Challenge

While it is imperative that we vet teachers as we hire for both what we need and what we can support, an even more important challenge will be retention. Once we have invested the time and money to ensure the very best hire, we must change our focus to retaining those teachers who are a quality fit or growing those individuals who do not yet fully meet the needs of our students and our organization.

It is wonderful when we have a quality hire and we must work to retain those individuals, but in today's reality, there will be times that we enter into a hiring relationship knowing that growth will be a necessity. Here's where we often begin, we are comfortable that this person will fit into our culture (something I would encourage you never to compromise on), we believe that this person, with support, can meet the needs of our students now and will "ultimately" meet the needs of our students without support. Finally, we know we have the leadership and coaching capacity to make that happen without detracting from other areas. When we realize that we are lacking in quality, we have no choice but to begin the process to help them grow.

Helping them Grow

Committing to quality instruction with a struggling teacher means we are stepping into the world of "Help them Grow". Sometimes we hire knowing that this is a commitment we'll need to undertake or discover this need later. Either way, our first goal should be to go "all in" to help this person become the quality educator we need for our students.

This commitment requires a deliberate focus from administration. It should be what I refer to as a "rock". **Our**

rocks are based on our values. They are based on all of the questions we asked in hiring from the start. So now the questions are focused directly around the needs of the teacher so that we can subsequently meet the needs of our students and maintain our culture within our academic framework.

So what does it look like to help them grow?

Let's begin with what it is NOT: Growth is NOT a list of excessive:

- directives for change
- meeting and trainings
- documentation
- observations

While all of these are components of a solid plan for growth, without a collaborative coaching model, these may result in compliance, but will not bring results.

The Time Commitment

Helping someone grow is slow, but we need it to be immediate. The only way to ensure quick growth is consistency and intentionality in the growth process, but a mere checklist of "to do's" won't cut it.

It takes a true, dedicated instructional cycle. This is a commitment; especially when you have a teacher that is not cutting it. It requires a clear understanding of the organization's philosophy and the gaps, clear goals and strategies for improvement, consistent observation and feedback, modeling and guided practice, and above all patience and understanding.

It's a lot to do as a leader which can lead to resentment. Many leaders skip the above because it is exhausting and find it hard to make the effort that makes the true impact. Documentation is faster than development. But if you skip the time, you skip the chance for growth and guarantee eventual turnover.

Here's a reminder, replacing a single teacher can cost districts thousands in recruitment, onboarding, training, and lost productivity but the greater cost is the learning time students never recover.

Growing struggling teachers (or administrators for that matter) is both powerful and uncomfortable. You carry hope and honesty simultaneously. You want success while preparing for the possibility it won't happen. Avoiding the conversation does not protect the person. It traps them.

The worst professional experience is not being coached out, it is being quietly tolerated. And even worse, this kind of apathy can be a true culture killer. Good teachers are often most disturbed and most likely to leave based on feeling that others who are not quality are "getting by". It feels inherently unfair and that is one thing good teachers truly cannot stomach.

The Process of Helping them Grow

Tiering Teachers to Build Strength and Trust

For a long time, I had approached leadership the way many of us do through monitoring. Observe more. Correct more. Send more emails. Have more meetings. Write more directives. Increase accountability. And when that didn't work, I moved to a growth plan which, if I'm honest, was usually documentation for an ending I had already decided.

This was a cycle I was not proud of and one that was frustrating and futile in nature. It is easy for leaders to feel overwhelmed by teacher development, but there are a few key realizations that changed everything for me personally and allowed me to not only grow and develop my struggling teachers, but have a meaningful impact on all of my teachers and the instruction within their classrooms.

I realized that not every teacher needed the same degree of attention, coaching, or direction and the key to success could be found in two ways: time spent developing struggling teachers

and time spent recognizing quality educators. This realization forced me to stop acting like the evaluator of instruction and become the teacher of teachers. This meant creating a tiered, differentiated process to help them grow or help them go. Monitoring could not be the strategy; development had to be the strategy.

There was also a second realization. Instead of hurting my culture by tolerating poor teachers, I could enhance my culture by growing those teachers. It meant recognizing that strong teachers and struggling teachers need different leadership. Tiering teachers became essential. Strong teachers require autonomy and creative space — and that freedom itself becomes an incentive to improve. Developing teachers need modeling, coaching, and repetition. And some teachers, through clarity and support, come to realize on their own they are simply in the wrong seat — or even the wrong bus.

This is not about firing people faster. It is about building classroom leaders while giving every adult an honest chance to grow into the role. It's about improving your culture so that EVERYONE feels valued, strong and struggling. If I'm struggling, you see me and you are willing to help. If I am strong, you see me and you trust me.

So what does "help them grow or help them go" look like? While it looks very different for each, the process of helping them grow or helping them go applies to and impacts every teacher, quality and struggling teachers alike.

Help them Grow or Help the Go-The Quality Teacher Version

Helping them grow applies equally to all the teachers.

For the strong, it requires ensuring that they are not only seen as quality, but are also given the opportunities to continue growing. We always want our best teachers to feel seen, heard, and valued and this process can absolutely help us do just that.

Even though our quality teachers may not appear to need to grow, we cannot deny our best teachers opportunities for professional development and growth. Nor can we continue to deny ourselves the opportunity to use them as a resource. Allowing them to hide behind closed doors and just "do their thing" should also not be an option. This not only limits their growth, it denies us our most valuable resource to assist struggling teachers and improve instruction for all.

So how do you help a quality teacher grow? Ask yourself the following questions about what you are doing to GROW your best teachers.

- When was the last time they attended a meaningful PD outside of your organization?
- What professional organizations do they participate in that you could encourage or pay for?
- What PD do they or can they provide for the rest of the staff?
- Who are they coaching, mentoring, or modeling?
- How do you acknowledge their work and celebrate their successes?
- How could you leverage and reward them financially for their expertise?
- How can you use them to leverage a program you want to move forward or give you more time with those who need you most?

These questions encourage us to both provide for and benefit from the growth of our best educators. We can spend a great deal of time concentrating on areas that need improvement, but this is about moving from GOOD to GREAT and is just as important as our focus on the ones who struggle.

Help them Grow or Help the Go-The Struggling Teacher Version

Helping a struggling teacher grow should be one of our main priorities. This involves being intentional, targeted, and consistent with a well-designed coaching strategy. The key word here is strategy. When trying to be both intentional and targeted, having a framework is key. I would advocate that anything that is done with fidelity can work. I have found a specific framework that has provided the most amazing and consistent results when it comes to growing teachers into or out of the classroom.

If you are familiar with the work of the DuFours in professional learning communities (PLC), you are aware of the power of PLCs to ensure quality instruction, assessment, and intervention. What you may not know is that these questions work equally well in growing teachers.

Professional learning community questions are intended to drive the work and the learning and ensure that there are checks and balances at each stage of the instructional process. By making teacher learning and improvement the focus of the questions, you can ensure teachers are growing or lay the foundation for change.

Teacher PLC Questions for Growth

Let's take a look at the three PLC questions and how they can be adapted to create teacher learning.

PLC Q. 1: ***"What do we want our students to learn, understand, and be able to do". For teachers, the question now becomes "what do our teachers need to learn, understand, and be able to do".***

We use question one to align our instructional framework and teacher requirements with the gaps we are seeing in our struggling teachers. This will give us the answers we need to know where to focus our time, attention, and resources. Once we begin with an aligned goal, we can create a schedule of consistent support that will ensure teachers are receiving what they need to raise their skill level to what is needed for quality instruction. We

use this question to tailor our support to close the gaps a teacher has in planning, organization, and instructional delivery.

PLC Q. 2: *"How will we know our teachers got it?*

One of the biggest mistakes leaders make when trying to grow a teacher is when they stop at question one. If we think that showing a teacher best practices and giving them a lesson plan template will solve all of their issues, we are stopping short of the most important piece- monitoring for if it actually worked.

"How will we know they got it?"

How will we know that the efforts we have made to grow our teachers are working? Just because we give a teacher a plan or a strategy and show them how to use it, does not mean that they will be able to do so effectively. We must *inspect what we expect* so that we can adjust as needed. Assumptions here can be fatal. This again is another time consuming part of the process that if missed, can defeat the entire process.

One thing that is very important to acknowledge when working with struggling teachers is that everyone is on a growth plan, not just the teacher. The administrator assigned to help the teacher grow is just as accountable as the teacher themselves. When students don't learn, we look to the teacher to see what they are doing that might be impeding the process, but do we do that when teachers are not growing? Everyone must work together to monitor and make needed changes in a timely fashion to have the best chance for success.

PLC Q. 3: *"What will we do when they don't learn?".*

The third question is where leadership courage lives. Because every growth plan eventually reaches a fork in the road where we must ask ourselves: did we help them grow or must we help them go? While there will be ups and downs in the process it is important to note that true growth is not completely linear. We have wins and we have setbacks as we are growing. That being said, we must have a clear point at which we know we are on the road to quality or we are at that fork where we will part ways.

Question three is where we must acknowledge that we have come to the decision point. Either we are making progress and we begin our exit strategy to pull back support until it is no longer needed or we recognize that no level of support will change the outcomes. While we hope we have made a positive impact and can document growth, this may be the point where we move into the "help them go" part of the process.

Helping them Go

You may have expected this article to continue with a guide for helping them go, but that is actually not necessary. Helping a teacher "go" is not a process. For those with whom we must part, it is actually a natural outcome of the process of helping them grow. For struggling teachers, you always hope they grow, but if after dedicated coaching support, there is still no teacher growth, it quickly becomes clear to everyone that "go" means no longer being a part of the organization in a teaching capacity.

Administrators dread these conversations. And while avoiding the conversation may protect feelings in the moment, it only guarantees the problem continues for students, for staff, and for culture. The beautiful part of the process to help them grow or help them go, is that just as you have realized it will not work to keep this individual, they too will often realize the role isn't right for them. The conversations had during the growth process are based on facts and clearly documented efforts and thus lay the foundation to have real discussions about performance. For me personally, since incorporating this strategy, I have found that I rarely if ever have to actually terminate someone. More often, they realize their own lack of growth or capacity and prefer to simply leave of their own choice with dignity.

There is also an additional benefit to this entire process. Remember we spoke of the strong teachers. With this process you are protecting your overall culture. Your strong teachers are always watching and they will be more inclined to stay because they know excellence is being protected. When helping a teacher to go, the goal is never removal. The goal is always alignment.

Whether it is helping them grow or helping them go, the process will serve the adults and students alike.

While growing is and should be the priority, there are times when letting go is the only option. When growth cannot or will not occur, replacement becomes necessary, not as punishment, but as protection of students and the organization. At the end of the day, the goal will always be the same**: a quality teacher in every classroom.** The best win is when they grow, but even when they don't, if done correctly, exits are not battles. They are accepting of it.

Leaders must always remember that **we are the teachers of teachers**. Helping them grow honors the person. Helping them go honors the mission. We should rest assured that regardless of the result, we have done our part to provide opportunities for growth and most importantly we are never choosing temporary comfort over long-term quality.

PART III

THE BUILDER: TURNAROUND & SCHOOL CLIMATE

My Take Action, Now

A Superintendent's Turnaround Story (Excerpt from Calculated Risk - Leadership Lessons & Stories)

by Yaw L. Obeng

About the Author



Yaw L. Obeng is an internationally recognized leader who has served as Superintendent in both Canada and the United States, including the Burlington School District in Vermont. His leadership is defined by a commitment to social justice, equity-centered policies, and social-emotional well-being. Obeng is known for stabilizing districts in crisis and developing innovative, multidisciplinary curricula, such as a nationally recognized aviation program. A frequent international speaker, he advocates for meaningful, community-integrated learning that empowers students to address real-world challenges. He has held senior roles in the Toronto and Halton District School Boards, bringing a global perspective to systemic reform. Obeng's work is driven by the belief that educators must lead with intentionality to dismantle inequities and provide every student with the tools for lifelong success.

Introduction

When I entered an underperforming school district in the middle of a global pandemic, I knew I was not just inheriting a system. I was stepping into an iceberg. What was visible were low achievement scores, high staff turnover, and financial instability. What lay beneath were years of cultural dysfunction, fractured governance, and eroded trust.

Turning around a school district is not unlike turning around a struggling enterprise or business. The same calculated risks, strategic discipline, and leadership clarity apply. What follows is how we moved from survival to sustained growth.

Clarity of Purpose:

School District Planning / Organization Planning: Focuses on developing mission and vision statements that emphasize educational goals, student development, and community engagement. The purpose is centered around improving student outcomes and overall educational quality.

Developing a plan involving a department or project team presents challenges encompassing both interpersonal (interactions between small groups of key people) and intrapersonal (interactions that happen within one's mind concerning others). Developing a plan that has clarity of purpose for an organization or thousands of individuals adds another layer of philosophical alignment challenges. This situation brought additional challenges for me as a leader. Practicing self-awareness is an asset. Moving quickly to a different part of the country and/or to another work environment requires paying attention to cultural nuances of the new region and/or organization in a much shorter time. Whenever you start to examine a new underperforming organization, the abilities of the staff and availability of appropriate resource supports come into question. It can be a complex situation to make quick

decisions without all the facts, as time is a constant variable. At the same time, there's often an unpredictable and unseen variable, an "iceberg" that can pose significant challenges. Be prepared for the unknown. An iceberg serves as a metaphor for hidden challenges, with only its tip visible above the surface while the much larger mass remains concealed beneath, representing unseen risks that can cause issues before they're fully recognized. The global pandemic was an iceberg, an unconventional challenge that had to be accounted for; however, it was impossible to predict all the outcomes that would affect planning. I was determined to find a way to do the needed analysis and information gathering in an authentic fashion. A decision had to be made, and I had to adjust to an unusual situation with unusual strategies. I decide to go all in on virtual and remote strategies. In a matter of two months, I was able to execute over 1400 individual meetings and over 50 group meetings. I gained access to federal, state and local politicians. Most of these individuals would not have spared the time in a traditional meeting. No way. People were willing to agree to connect virtually for 15 minutes.

Not a single meeting ended in less than 20 minutes. Once individuals understood your moral purpose and how it connected to them personally or professionally, they became engaged. I applied the same strategy to community leaders and staff departments. The insights were remarkable. You can imagine the range of participants. One day, within the span of 30 seconds, I went from discussing legislative impacts with a state legislator to speaking with a parent of five about the rising cost of diapers.

The contrast between these conversations highlighted the diverse range of issues I navigated. The investigation was an exciting and educational endeavor concerning the human condition. This seamlessly focused my listening skills to try and garner a golden nugget in each conversation about people's needs and then focused that on my mission. I started hearing a variation on the phrase "What I want" or "What we want for our kids." This phrasing helped to focus the mission and vision of the

work needed to come. The entry plan report I created was an attempt to crystallize my vision into a shared vision with the people who could help make the change. The entry plan report would bring a voice to the vision. The document was titled **"HMC-1… The Future We Want"**

Business Plan:

This plan focuses on defining the company's mission and vision, which emphasize business goals, customer satisfaction, and market positioning. The purpose is centered around profitability, market share, and business growth.

Risk Assessment

School District Planning: Identifies potential risks such as financial constraints, staffing issues, safety concerns, and changes in educational standards. Risk management plans are developed to address these challenges, often with a focus on ensuring continuity in education and safety.

One thing that has been proven about significant organizational change is that finances must be in order and aligned for the organization to maneuver toward thriving and succeeding. I knew this and had seen both sides of the pendulum. Finance drives whatever vision, mission, or priorities you establish. Your financial plan is the articulation of your strategic plan, and it should focus on consistent stability with minimal risk. The organization faced some financial challenges in the past along with severe cuts and reductions and had to fight to restore a 'good' credit rating. Credit ratings not only determine credit worthiness but also predict future risk. It establishes a public perception and assists investors and stakeholders in making an informed decision about your organization. Minimizing risk is a

crucial task to garner support for the actions that will need to be accomplished.

We established a financial management system that would guide us toward success. An effective financial management system is crucial for an organization because it helps manage and optimize financial resources, ensuring financial stability and strategic goals support. I tried to keep it as simple as possible for easy monitoring for our staff, board, and stakeholders. After reviewing all relevant policies and legislation in our industry related to finance, the system was divided into three major categories: Financial Conditions & Activities, Financial Planning & Budgeting, and Asset Protection. Board oversight mechanisms, including external audits, internal monitoring reports, and direct inspection methods, were essential components to ensure accountability and transparency. I always made sure that a structure was in place that, if I were to depart the organization, I would leave behind a strong team of competent managers and a paper trail of effective actions and documentation of meticulous records that reflected the long-term vision and ensured continued success in my absence.

FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT SYSTEM	
POLICIES	**BOARD OVERSIGHT ACTIONS**
Financial Conditions & Activities Financial Planning & Budgeting Asset Protection	Hire External Auditor Monitoring Mechanism External Audit Internal Reports Direct Inspection

Stakeholder Review Level (Communication Transparency)	District Schools School Partners Economic Partners
Board Monitoring Reports	Financial Activities Financial Planning/Budget Asset Protection
Financial Procedures	External Controls Procedures Security Measures Internal Controls
Finance Documents	Financial Plan Line Budget Document (Paper Trail)Website

After some clear indicators, like clean financial audits and proposals from financial institutions, I felt the timing was right to take action. A Corporate Financial Portfolio was created for the first time, which is not very typical of non-profit organizations. Ideally, this prompts questions about some guidelines around what our risk appetite and risk tolerance is. We certainly cannot afford a major downfall with a significant loss of funds. Therefore, building a portfolio at a level of low risk enables us to start establishing a solid foundation. A culture change was happening among our staff. We started operating from a position of strength and not from that of a low-wealth organization. The cog was turning. We were able to take this driving force into the community with support from our many stakeholders to establish a revenue generator. Enabling a tax increase that would provide the funds to make our teaching force the highest paid in the area.

On election day we knew the machine was starting to move when we received overwhelming support from voters. Momentum was building and some of the cogs were starting to

ignite and interact at the right time. The media and others in our industry began to notice our efforts, but most importantly, it reinforced that our risky actions were yielding positive results. This significantly enabled us to attract great talent and retain quality personnel. Our portfolio had other revenue generating strategies, like grants and services, but the tax increment would give us sustained consistent financing. Our fund balance or surplus grew to over 54 percent. (A healthy surplus is four percent!) It was a calculated risk decision to target our initial public financial investment endeavor promoting and assisting our workforce, which was a primary focus of our strategy. There were many pressing needs that would present challenges but more than any purchase or written plan, effective people would bring us toward "The Future We Want."

Business Plan: Identifies potential risks such as market fluctuations, competition, regulatory changes, and operational issues. Risk management plans are developed to mitigate these risks with a focus on maintaining business operations and profitability.

Informed Decision Making

School District Planning: Decisions are based on data collection and analysis related to student performance, teacher effectiveness, and community feedback. The aim is to improve academic achievement, social-emotional wellness, and employability skills.

In any organization, your most valuable asset is your people because your staff 's performance correlates directly to your outcomes. My experiences have taught me that the human factor is something that always should be considered in how you utilize the qualitative and quantitative data collected to inform your

decisions. We want to have data-informed decisions nuanced with awareness of human behavior that assists a progressive movement. In developing and implementing a plan, you want to apply some **"T -N- T**." Not the actual dynamite kind but an explosive humanistic strategy. Tough and Tender. Tough on our targets and goals while being Tender on our people. But you must have quality people.

Our data indicated a 25% staff turnover rate every year. Having an entirely new staff cohort every four years was not sustainable. The national organization turnover rate was about 4%; unfortunately, in the education sector, it ranged from 10-14% teacher turnover. In urban areas, it is higher depending on the situation. Teacher retention is a key factor in providing a high-quality education that directly supports student performance, school stability, and a positive educational environment. Our student achievement data reflected this underwhelming reality. In some of our student cohorts, nearly 70% of our scholars were performing two grades below their grade level.

Astonishing! Having 20% of students underperforming on their grade level tells you there is a systemic instructional strategy problem. Clearly, we had a broken cog.

An immediate and decisive decision had to be made to start a remedy for this problem. **We had already raised our teacher salaries to attract and retain the best.** Economic compensation attracts people but in the long term, it does not provide sustained commitment. Compensation, along with building a positive culture, is what retains good employees. One of the things we did was acknowledge individuals who were delivering positive results. We also listened to these individuals when they told us what worked in their classrooms or teams. Something was working because they were outliers among underperforming groups in the same situation. These individuals demonstrated an intrapreneurial mindset in their jurisdictions. They were expert tacticians. Exceptional tacticians can intuitively gather relevant data from the broad scope of our objectives and respond swiftly to implement changes in real time. These are the types of assets and special people who could

make a difference. We needed more of them to implement at a systemic level. With a solid financial foundation, we were able to allocate funds for an intervention strategy that would require these teacher experts immediately. A campaign was started targeting retired teachers who could come in a few days a week and work exclusively with small student groups. We saw immediate results with students improving their reading fluency and comprehension scores in a matter of weeks. When you identify a good thing, you need to respond swiftly and grease the wheels to move even faster and effectively. We quickly formalized the program with each student having their achievement plan with a cycle of periodic measurement. Several weeks of direct feedback was essential to change instruction, motivate students' progress, and engage parents rather than the usual report card cycle or an annual assessment.

To have a system implementation of quality educators, we had to aggressively seek retired educators who had the experience and were easy to train for the program while also significantly reducing behavior challenges during lessons. We motivated each principal or building manager to find one special educator to commit to two or three days a week. Once we had a small group, we applied the old Faberge Shampoo commercial strategy: "Tell two friends, and they tell two friends, and so on, and so on…" We eventually had an army of dedicated professionals. This resulted in more students showing growth sooner than later. We improved our service, evidenced by a 14% increase in academic achievement and an additional 3-5% growth each year thereafter. Retention was no longer a concern, as reflected in our climate and culture feedback, which showed over 90% satisfaction. Teacher turnover decreased significantly, dropping to 16% in the first year and then to 12% in the subsequent years, and continued to improve from there. You get the picture.

Business Plan: Decisions are based on market research, financial data, and customer feedback. The aim is to optimize business operations, improve product or service offerings, and increase profitability.

Strategic Planning

School District Planning: Develops a long-term strategic plan focused on academic, operational, and financial goals. Resource allocation supports these priorities, and detailed implementation plans for educational initiatives are developed.

In developing a strategic plan, you need to have clear targets that you want to hit. Someone once said a plan without measurable actions and goals is just a dream. The only way to make a dream come true is to have clear steps to achieve it. Any good business plan has clear indicators that ensure you are on the right path and/or suggestions to course correct. Our organizational plan was a group of good ideas, but it was not connected to measurable goals. It lacked the strategic focus to achieve what we wanted to accomplish. Even the state criticized the ambiguity and lack of data-driven actions. We did, however, feel good about our three pillar areas of school, district, and community because it encompassed all the stakeholders. We needed to strategically build on these foundational pillars. I could see now that we had a Clarity of Purpose with enough moral essence and points of conversion-like connections of multiple cogs to provide the determination needed to define a plan around "The Future We Want.".

This led to our strategic plan road map called **"Crossroads to the Future,"** which connected the dreams to actionable steps.

Risk Assessment- In assessing risk, finance emerged as a

significant roadblock. However, the foundation had been established with the

Financial Management System, complemented by strategies involving tax increments, bonds, financial investment portfolios, and grants. This set the stage for a catalyst, the engine that would drive the plan forward.

Informed Decision Making - We have established a human resources framework to ensure sound decision-making at every level. By hiring quality experts through incentives, culture building initiatives, and positive social media campaigns, we have positioned ourselves as an employer of choice in the industry, another cog in our well-connected system.

Strategic Plan - All the cogs for developing our strategic plan were ready to be assembled together. A decision had to be made regarding developing specific measurable actions and narrowing the focus. Narrowing the strategic focus allows one to make good decisions on resource allocation and resource concentration, and this assists in making decisions regarding new initiatives and/or staying the course to achieve your current goals. You understand what your priorities are on a daily basis.

Organizations are complex and plans can become overly complicated if you do not focus on simplicity. There is a difference between complex and complicated; avoid making complexity unnecessarily complicated. Simplify it. You must have a way of effectively channeling your energy. So, our three priorities were simple and what our organization needed: achievement, system alignment, and fine facilities.

Let me share examples in Fine Facilities. The community had already voiced a need to improve the blight that had gradually spread in the residential and commercial areas. Gone were the days when you could find housing and everything you needed down the street. This blight affects who chooses to live in the area, thus impacting our district enrollment leading to low resources to facilitate change. It is kind of like the chicken before the egg thing. How do we insert this challenge into our plan to make a measurable difference? Well, being a taxing jurisdiction

can have its advantages. You can use your tax abatement power to incentivize businesses and development to invest in your product. Any investment has levels of risk, so determine your risk tolerance for your decision. However, our branding campaign was proving effective in attracting residential development that had been stagnant for decades. One project that we were particularly excited about was a partnership to bring a grocery store to an area that had previously been designated a food desert. Food deserts are areas where people have limited to no choices of healthy foods. This became a great morale boost for the community and aligned with our core mission of serving students to be mentally healthy and physically sound scholars. Since my childhood, my mother always told me that charity begins at home. I never really understood it as a child until I started seeing the disadvantages people have without the right support. We were attempting to secure the basic needs from home to school so learning could happen.

Another opportunity presented itself when we were able to purchase a blighted building and rebuild it into a Real World Learning Center. The market data indicated that over 60% of our students were going directly into the workforce after graduation. We still had a traditional no-risk educational program that spoke to only the university-bound graduates, reflective of typical pathways our teachers and administrators took: Go and get multiple degrees, and you will succeed. This is not the reality of society. We needed to create multiple successful pathways, for in the real world, only about 30% have four-year degrees. I am a great supporter of higher education but not disillusioned to think it guarantees one an occupation. From a business perspective, we were not preparing all students to compete in the marketplace. Construction and skilled trades were underserved but had high wages. There was a clear supply and demand for skilled workers. Therefore, our center would start with programs for students to earn credentials in the trades. That followed with the biomedical division, entrepreneurial business, technology, etc. even a student-operated cafe for the community. Also offered was a program to learn a business from hospitality to accounting. Our vision was **"Turning Experiences into Opportunities,"** and it was exciting to see our hard work come

together and make a difference in students' lives. These ideas were percolating while developing of our Strategic Plan (Crossroads To The Future). To move from a paper document into reality takes incredible energy and system alignment. Each person has to understand their role. How do you bring individual drive to form a collective strategic focus? There must be ways to make the plan come alive. Usually, in the education sector, we create multiple improvement plans and attach flowery titles as the meaning of the document, titles like " Striving for Success Tomorrow"; " Creating Contributing Members of Society"; and " Excellence in Reaching for the Top." It was imperative that I find a way to give our plan and challenges an identity reflective of our staff and community efforts. It needed to be something that described our essential characteristics, a battle cry that signified our presence and continuous movement. After a few discussions and debates, I woke up in the middle of the night after a long day of brainstorming. I was never one to dwell on the saying about what keeps you up at night, but this issue was gnawing at me, and I knew I needed to get it right. To channel my excess energy, I found myself burning it off on my elliptical. Exercise on an elliptical can help calm the nerves and induce a meditative state. The continuous, rhythmic movements, along with the focus on coordinating arm movements, breathing pace, and leg rotation contribute to this effect. The combination of physical activity, endorphin release, and mental focus makes elliptical workouts a soothing and meditative experience for me. As I powered up a hill stage, breathing heavily and thinking of nothing but completing the climb, symbolizing the struggle of this project. The downhill brought an ease and calm which crystallized all the ideas circling my mind into a singular word:

RELENTLESS

Our plan is relentless about achieving the goals. This became our battle cry and signature for both the district and the community, an identity fitting of the history.

Business Plan: Develops a long-term strategic plan focused on business growth, market expansion, and financial

targets. Resource allocation is geared toward product development, marketing, and operational efficiency.

Proactive Monitoring

School District Planning: Conducts regular performance reviews using key performance indicators (KPIs) related to educational outcomes. Establishes feedback mechanisms to gather input from students, teachers, and parents, fostering a culture of continuous improvement.

Proactively monitoring a plan is critical to guiding toward success. whether it is your endeavor or organizational functions. An intrapreneurial approach ensuring proactive actions to correct and mitigate challenges is a necessity for long-term success. You can have a plan and get lucky in the short-term because obstacles are overshadowed by other variables. For instance, you can throw money at a problem, and it could mask the real issues for a period of time. Then try a different band-aid solution by throwing more money until you identify strategies for the real cause. It is a never-ending battle and additional funds cannot instigate continued positive change. Eventually, you understand that good stewardship is what can maneuver around hurdles.

In our case, boards of Education are the primary stewards in partnership with the CEO- Superintendent. Boards hold the key to this maneuvering and monitoring process. I have served on and reported to many boards in my career. Public boards and private boards have distinct characteristics. Private sector boards operate like assembling a championship team; they selectively choose individuals with specific skill sets to create a well-rounded group. Different types of cogs are needed to work together effectively, and they strategically seek out individuals

with expertise in areas such as legal matters, finance, and organizational leadership.

In contrast, public boards offer anyone in the community the opportunity to serve, which can enrich community stakeholder involvement and help maintain focus on the primary mission.. I have always had respect for individuals who volunteer their time to this elected service, just like President Truman (Former Board Member) did so many years ago. There is no pay and frequently no appreciation from those you serve. Democracy has its challenges. That anyone can serve, means that, for better or worse, ANYONE can serve. Sometimes individuals make decisions that are self-serving in the guise of the greater good. Public school boards across the nation have seen minimal changes over the last several decades with all kinds of behaviors. The school district's/ organizational success relies heavily on effective board governance, education, political acumen, and the selfless dedication of each Board member. When school boards fail to function properly, it's often because dysfunction took root long before it became visible. This was the case with HMC-1, where decades of organizational toxicity manifested in various forms, including election disputes, split boards, voting stalemates, board incivility, vacancies, resignations, and character attacks. Good governance over the years was inconsistent, unfortunately tainting good board members and boards. Inevitably the issues led to a continuous turnover of superintendents/CEOs and leadership teams.

We had a strong strategic plan and significant human capacity but needed leadership at the governance level to monitor, support, and give direction. Unfortunately, we were in a state of dysfunction. The board was divided in their alliances, which prompted decisions biased by payback and personal grievances. What really revealed the iceberg was the resignation of one board member. This made the voting dynamics a three-to three tie on everything, meaning a vote would fail because a majority of four was required. Even the process of adding a temporary board member was undecided several times with a three-to-three tie. It escalated to the point that we could not have a board meeting because it required four members to agree on the

agenda. Now, it had a direct and obvious impact on our plan and the work that needed to get done. It was impossible to present a recommendation, have a clear vote, and take the necessary action to further our cause. We could not have a meeting to elect a president to shepherd through a process. According to policies, this left me as transitional president and superintendent CEO, at the same time! Not a good situation when you are stuck in the middle of your bosses. When mommy and daddy are fighting, no one wins. Something had to be done. There are levels of politics in every decision, but this had risen from small-p politics, to big-P politics. Big-P politics deals with the scope of formal structures and processes of government and public affairs debates of policies, legislation, and regulations. We were always on a collision course to this point, and the signs along the way said as much. The month before I started the position, a stalemate at the board meeting occurred, leaving a member in tears and unresolved issues. It was predictable that the ongoing tolerance of dysfunctional small-p politics, intertwined with the informal, interpersonal negotiations of everyday power dynamics, had culminated in the peak of the iceberg. Now, the entire behemoth was exposed for all to see. The media certainly could see it. This could bring down all the work. This was truly a leadership moment and it was time to meditate and summon clarity of thought. In these moments, one needs to connect back for the Clarity of Purpose and refocus one's determination and attention on that obstacle.

The traditional approaches had not worked, so the timing called for clarity that could search for an intrapreneurial solution.

Reaching back to my past experiences, I attempted to consult board members one-by-one on a pathway forward. The conversations were difficult and reminded me of my Israel - Palestinian conversations where opinions were so historically ingrained. Finally, I decided to try something that was indeed intrapreneurial and novel which would pose many challenges. I assembled what was later called the "Elephant Summit." I had a stuffed elephant in my office representing the unspoken cause or grievance. You know the phrase "the elephant in the room"—a barrier to productive conversations about progress. To address

this, I initiated mediation between two members representing the opposing factions. The elephant was rotated around to claim the talking space, so whoever had the elephant held the power to speak, similar to the conch in the story "Lord of the Flies" when warring factions had to convene. The Elephant was rotated around to share the power. At this point, conversations could easily become uncivil and had at times. I inserted probing questions trying to guide the conversation. After several failed attempts, finally, a break-through when two board members decided something had to be done and coalesced around the moral purpose of our students. In the grievances, the individuals had lost sight of the mission of the board. These two women would agree to save our plan and restore governance and ultimately the benefits to students.

Years ago, I learned a Chinese word that meant change and opportunity - Weiji. I think about this in crisis moments sometimes. This Chinese word that encompasses both "change" and "opportunity" "危机" (wēijī), always intrigued me for its historical context. How many times throughout history has positive change come out of a conflict? The word is often translated as "crisis" in English, but it is composed of two Chinese characters: "危" (wēi), meaning "danger" or "risk," and "机" (jī), meaning "opportunity" or "crucial point." This concept reflects the idea that within a crisis, there is both danger and the potential for opportunity. I saw an opportunity in this moment to change the cultural behavior that had existed in our governance for a while. A crucial point. Because there may never be another opportunity to seize the moment, I proposed the idea of co-presidents: a sharing of power by combining their influence from both factions. I did some research with the state association lawyers to determine if this was legal or possible. Debates ensued among lawyers, board members, and the community if this idea was possible. On the night of the special meeting to decide, there was palpable tension. We had not been able to call a meeting for almost two months, and there was a full audience to witness this event. The outcome hung over like a cloud. Yet, the risk was taken, and danger was averted. The two candidates had put in the work needed with their colleagues in

preparation and were elected as Co-Presidents. Once again HMC-1 had demonstrated leadership in a historic way. The state association stated for the first time in state history a school board would have co-presidents. The legislation governing education law lacked this provision, which could be subject to contestation. This was a calculated risk, but there had not been any other practical solutions presented. I devised a tactic to ensure strategic success, but it was the willingness of the two board members that made it possible. In fact, in the end, all board members had to co-operate for this action to happen. A credit to them all. This was a critical moment in our journey, as it was an opportunity to change the culture of our governance and ensure sustained progress. They went on to support the implementation of the ideas laid out in our plan, such as: A structure through board meetings with monitoring reports to validate each section of the plan; indicators and products that represented the results; financial strategies to maintain a healthy fund balance; redesign and open of two middles schools focusing on Fine Arts and Science Technology Engineering Math; the Real World Learning Center was opened; and we even launched a program that provided free laptops and Wi-Fi for all parents, and more.

In the end, this was not merely a story about stabilizing finances, raising test scores, or repairing governance, it was a story about restoring belief. When leadership is anchored in moral purpose, informed by data, and carried forward with relentless resolve, even the most fragile systems can be transformed. Educational turnarounds do not begin with policies or programs; they begin with leaders willing to take calculated risks in service of children, and communities willing to rise together to claim a better future.

Excerpt From Yaw L. Obeng - Calculated Risk: Leadership Lessons & Stories yawobeng.com

Not Every Child Can Be Successful in the Same Environment: Understanding and Creating an Alternative School Environment

By Dr. Kevin Scanlon

About the Author



Dr. Kevin Scanlon is the Superintendent of the Three Village Central School District on Long Island, returning to lead the community where his career began. With over 30 years in education, he has held key leadership roles, including high school principal in the Roslyn School District and Assistant Superintendent for Educational Services. His approach is shaped by his early experience as a social studies teacher and his eight years of service in the U.S. Naval Reserve, which instilled a disciplined, service-oriented mindset. Dr. Scanlon is known for his commitment to transparency, data-informed decision-making, and fostering collaborative district cultures. He remains dedicated to ensuring that administrative policy remains closely aligned with the classroom experience, driving both academic excellence and strong community engagement across the district.

Introduction

Since the inception of public school education, the goal has been to provide an educational environment for every child, regardless of their socioeconomic background. Although over the course of 200 years of public school education, our nation has dealt with issues of equality and poverty, the intent of public schools was to be the great equalizer. No longer was formal education an opportunity for the wealthy or elite.

However, over the past 50 years, it has become clear that not every student can succeed, let alone function, in large schools. Issues such as school phobia and anxiety have caused students to fear attending large school environments. It often impedes their ability to sustain their attention and learn.

After 35 years in education, I have devoted a large portion of my career to either teaching in or supervising alternative education environments. I taught for 10 years at a large alternative night school that held classes four nights a week, with three-and-a-half-hour sessions. The district took in 1,700 students from 27 school districts in the region. Many of these students had children, were involved in gangs, or were working to support their families in jobs during the day.

The Need for an Alternative School

As a Principal, I founded an alternative high school in a high-wealth district. Even though the high school had approximately 1,100 students, it was daunting for some of those students to navigate the size and structure of the school environment. Another contributing factor began to merge with the rampant use of social media and cyber-bullying. The smaller setting and class sizes allow teachers to build close relationships with students. Attendance improved, and so did their grades, since they were no longer missing school because of their anxiety.

Fast forward seven years, as an Assistant Superintendent for Educational Services, I was charged by the Superintendent to

create an alternative high school in another much larger district. There were three attempts to create the alternative program, each of which failed. The high school in this district had 1,800 students across three grade levels, and 9th grade was split between two junior high schools. We visited my former district and its alternative school, as well as programs in other districts, before finalizing the vision for the alternative school.

The first group of students to attend had not attended any of the district's schools throughout their educational experience. The worst part about this was that they were mostly seniors. Yet through the efforts of the alternative school's administration, faculty, and staff, 19 seniors enrolled, 19 graduated, and 19 went to college in that first year.

How was this accomplished? It was done by selecting the right administration, faculty, and staff for the jobs. Who the people are as human beings matters just as much, if not more, than their academic acumen. A teenager can see right through whether you care about them or not. Like Malcolm Gladwell said in his novel *Blink*, your first perception of someone within two minutes of meeting them is usually the most accurate. For teenagers, I believe it is less than that. The administration, faculty, and staff selected to be part of an alternative school must understand one word: Flexibility. If they are too rigid, they will be frustrated. Although students need boundaries, this alternative school provides them with them; they also need understanding, compassion, and care. Teachers in this environment need to really enjoy working with kids. (Which should be the number one question we ask all teachers before we hire them.)

We hold a separate graduation and prom for the alternative school students. They are welcome to attend the high school's graduation and prom, but most always choose their own over the high school's programs. We have to bring boxes of tissues in and distribute them to the administration, faculty, and staff, along with the families, because the student speakers make them cry each year as they tell their stories of being lost and now found, being seen as a nobody and feeling like you contribute, and feeling worthless and knowing you are loved.

Working in an alternative school setting will challenge your teaching abilities. You will either get better at your craft or quit. The challenges you face will determine your own character, but the rewards are tremendous. Each year, at our Board of Education Recognition program, a student from the alternative school speaks to the Board and thanks them. Each year, the one sentence that makes everyone cry is when a student says, “This school saved my life.” How do you put a price tag on that?

Ensuring Safety, Wellness, and Belonging as the Guardian

By Dr. Will Pickens

About the Author



Dr. Will Pickens is a Deputy Chief of Schools for Chicago Public Schools, where he provides strategic leadership to a vast network of urban schools. With an 18-year career that includes serving as Deputy Superintendent in South Carolina, he has a comprehensive view of school operations and student support services. Dr. Pickens specializes in the "invisible architecture" of educational systems—the administrative frameworks that enable instructional excellence. His background as a Title 1 reading teacher and school counselor informs his focus on the "whole child," integrating mental health resources into the fabric of school life. Known for navigating high-stakes environments with transparency, he is a driving force for equity and academic rigor. His leadership ensures administrative decisions are always centered on closing achievement gaps and supporting student growth.

The Weight of the Return

On July 1, 2020, I transitioned back to South Carolina to serve as the Chief of Administrative Services and Deputy Superintendent. The district sits just 30 minutes south of my hometown, Charlotte, North Carolina. For any professional, a "homecoming" of this magnitude carries a specific kind of weight—the desire to prove your worth in the place that raised you.

On the surface, I was the definition of "having it all." I was 35 years old, stepping into a high-level central office role, nearing the completion of my dissertation, and preparing for the birth of my first child in December. I was closer to my family than I had been in years. By many metrics, I was a success story.

Yet, underneath the accolades, the reality was far more complex. The world was reeling from the COVID-19 pandemic, and the social fabric of America was being pulled apart by racial tension. Personally, I was navigating a private battle with my own mental health—a struggle I kept behind a curtain, unshared even with those closest to me. My life felt like a scale perfectly balanced between professional triumph and internal trial. However, I realized quickly that this new position wasn't just a job; it was a God-given platform to turn my own empathy into action.

The Brain and the Heart: Defining the Central Office

My role as Chief of Administrative Services was expansive. It included everything from managing school improvement councils and board policy to social-emotional learning (SEL), attendance, and discipline. I also served as the district's hearing officer and ombudsman—the person often tasked with finding a middle ground when tensions were highest.

I was incredibly fortunate to work alongside a superintendent who didn't just hire me, but actively positioned me to lead. We had a Board of Education that understood the nuance of our work and a cabinet of chief officers who balanced high intelligence with deep humility.

In this environment, I developed a core philosophy: The schools are the heartbeat of the community, and the central office is the brain. The heart keeps the body alive and vibrant, but the brain must provide the signals, the safety protocols, and the nourishment to keep that heart beating steadily. Our primary responsibility in the central office is to ensure that every school is a "beacon of hope", a place where students aren't just names on a roster, but individuals who are seen, valued, and heard.

Strategy 1: Leverage Data—Don't Weaponize It

In leadership circles, we often talk about "data-driven decisions," but we rarely talk about the *spirit* in which that data is used. Quantitative and qualitative data can help us tell a story, but they are never the whole story. Data is information; it is a diagnostic tool, not a tool to be used for punishment.

Central office teams must learn to triangulate data points to get the clearest picture of district health. This requires us to analyze the information, find the gaps, ask the uncomfortable questions and most importantly, take radical ownership of the results. There is a hard truth in education:

If the schools are not successful, the central office has failed**.**

When accountability starts at the top, a culture of support naturally flows down to the classrooms.

What data should we be "pouring over"? Effective leaders look beyond just test scores. They look at:

- **Attendance & Chronic Absenteeism:** The first barrier to learning is physical presence.
- **Discipline Trends:** Are expulsions and suspensions hitting specific demographics harder than others?
- **Climate Surveys:** Do the students feel safe? Do the teachers feel supported?
- **Classroom Observations:** What is the "vibe" when you walk the halls?

When we use this data to "browbeat" principals, we create a culture of fear. Fear travels through a district at a lightning pace,

and a fearful teacher cannot effectively inspire a child. If we want students to feel a sense of belonging, we must offer that same psychological safety to the adults in the building. You cannot have one without the other.

Strategy 2: Systems and Structures as a Safety Net

Good intentions do not scale; systems do. The central office must have rigorous structures in place to monitor and assess student wellness. It isn't enough to *say* we care about belonging; we have to build the machinery that ensures it.

When evaluating your systems, consider these four questions:

1. **Metric Clarity:** What specific data points are we monitoring on a weekly or monthly basis?
2. **The Definition of "Win":** What does success actually look like for these wellness metrics? If we don't define the goal, we can't celebrate the victory.
3. **Alignment:** Does every principal and teacher know what those goals are, or are they a "central office secret"?
4. **The Support Loop:** What is my team's specific role in removing the obstacles the schools are facing?

Central office goals should be an amalgamation of school-level goals. If a district wants to decrease chronic absenteeism by 5%, that doesn't happen in a boardroom—it happens through strategic actions at the school. Once the systems are clear, the central office must provide the necessary resources: People, Professional Development, and Funding**.** If a school lacks the structure to support its students, it is the central office's job to either help them build it or build it alongside them. When support is attached to expectations, accountability grows taller.

Strategy 3: The Power of Authentic Partnerships

Every week, I receive a lot of emails from vendors. While many are cold calls, I make it a point to briefly research any organization that may align with our vision. Why? Because no

district is an island. Regardless of the problem you are trying to solve—whether it's literacy gaps, mental health crises, or aging infrastructure—there is likely an organization that has spent decades perfecting the solution.

If your "wheels are stuck in the mud," don't be afraid to ask for a tow. This applies to neighboring districts as well. Educators are some of the smartest people on earth and we also sometimes have the most parochial views. We tell our school leaders and teachers to be innovative, yet we will not reach out to a neighboring school district that is 12 minutes away and is solving the exact problem that we have. Collaborating with other school districts in and out of your state can be an extraordinary partnership; A partnership that can help unlock solutions for your district, which will ultimately be good for kids.

Innovating doesn't always mean inventing something new; sometimes, it means being humble enough to call a colleague and ask, "How did you do it?"

Turning the Tide on Trauma: A Case Study

When I stepped into my role, I began by looking at our **Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACE)** scores. The data was startling. High ACE scores meant our students and many of our staff were carrying significant trauma into the classroom every day.

The research is undeniable. Trauma fundamentally alters how a child learns and behaves. At the time, our district had high rates of expulsion and suspension. Many well-intended leaders believed that removing a "disruptive" student was the only way to maintain order. However, there is no evidence that suspension changes a student's behavior for the better. In fact, it often does the opposite. We realized we had to shift from being a punitive district to a trauma-informed one. We partnered with the Spartanburg Academic Movement, a nonprofit dedicated to strengthening student wellbeing.

The Rollout Strategy: We didn't start with the students; we started with the leadership.

1. The Board of Education: We presented the vision and the "why." By securing their buy-in early, we ensured the governing body could champion the initiative to the community.
2. The Senior Leadership: We trained the Superintendent and the cabinet.
3. The Front Lines: We moved to principals, then assistant principals, and finally school counselors.

By following this order, we ensured that by the time the initiative reached the classroom, the entire chain of command understood and supported it. We eventually selected five leaders from across the district—myself included—to undergo intensive training to become certified trauma-informed leaders.

This led to the creation of a digital, comprehensive SEL resource hub that gave every teacher and counselor immediate access to tools for student health and wellbeing. We didn't just give them a mandate; we gave them a toolkit.

The Implementers of Change

At the end of the day, central office strategies are just theories until a teacher walks into a classroom. Teachers and staff are the true heroes of this work. They are the ones who turn "safety, wellness, and belonging" from a section in a handbook into a lived reality.

Without the buy-in of our educators, we have theory without action. Our job in the "brain" of the district is to ensure that the "heart"—our schools—has everything it needs to beat strong, steady, and full of hope.

PART IV

THE PATHFINDER: CONNECTING SCHOOLS TO THE REAL WORLD

Before Graduation: Developing Career Readiness across the K-12 Education System through Systemic Change Thinking

By Curtis M. Clough

About the Author



Curtis Clough is a veteran educator and administrator with a career spanning over 35 years, during which he has held nearly every possible role within the school system. Currently, he is working with 9 rural districts in New Mexico helping redesign rural workforce for maximum impact from PreK to adult transitions. Clough's vast experience provides him with a rare, 360-degree view of the educational landscape. His career began in an unexpected place—studying accounting at Ohio State University—before a shift in passion led him to the classroom. Since then, he has served as a teacher, high school principal, athletic director, assistant superintendent, superintendent and state-level administrator. Notably, he served as Alaska's state administrator for career-technical education (CTE), where he was responsible for aligning the K-12 curriculum with workforce demands and vocational excellence across one of the most geographically diverse states in the country. and is currently bringing that background and expertise to the state of New Mexico.

Introduction

Current models for Career and Technical Education tend to focus on the later stages of a student's career, once they reach high school, to align with the pathways offered at that school or at a higher education institution where a relationship exists. Research is showing that this will be too late for many students, as they are making poor life decisions that will have an impact on their ability to access high-quality careers, such as drug use or poor decisions that impact access to certain pathways.

In New Mexico, a group of rural schools is trying to change the narrative by working together collaboratively so that, no matter what their geographic location, students will have the ability to pursue their career passions and desires with high-quality programs that meet local and regional workforce needs. These districts are implementing the P20 Career and Technical Education network, Preschool to Postsecondary, so all students have access to high-quality careers and receive the career readiness skills during the elementary years of their education, so that they are fully prepared upon graduation to pursue a career or further training or education, so they become viable members of society and our economy.

The New Mexico Rural Workforce Collaborative, informally known as the New Mexico P20 Network, is an extensive approach to overhaul and implement a system that enables students in rural areas to gain access from Preschool through High School to the knowledge, skills, and abilities they need to improve career readiness across the state. The participating districts use a five-piece framework to align activities and recruit participants, expanding access to high-quality careers and pathways that align with local, regional, and statewide workforce needs. This has been a year-long process, but the lessons learned can be applied to the implementation of any system overhaul or change for educational improvement and student engagement. This model is similar to other P20 initiatives across the country, but each state has its own unique policies and political context that affect the ability to implement and sustain it. New Mexico

launched this initiative in August 2024 and has adapted to the state's ever-changing educational environment. The collaborative has been very methodical and systematic in developing the model to ensure full fidelity and transparency with stakeholders and political entities that are beginning to support meaningful change in our educational thinking and system. The framework is the guide for all of our work. It allows for open dialogue and discussions that align with the goals of all, including student success and access to high-quality career opportunities.

The P20 Engagement Framework is a set of five steps that align and establish operational expectations and support, leading to greater access and common alignment of stakeholders' goals and objectives for student career readiness. The five steps are:

1. Establish a shared vision with all stakeholders.
2. Align stakeholder goals and objectives with existing or new pathways for success.
3. Create access for all to high-quality work-based learning/project-based learning opportunities.
4. Eliminate barriers to student access while advancing local and regional needs with comprehensive support systems across all stakeholders.
5. Make data-driven decisions and high-quality support for the professional development of staff.

The first step in the framework is to establish a shared vision of the network's goals and objectives, as well as those of potential stakeholders, including the workforce and higher education. Too often in education, we use acronyms and phrases specific to our field and do not engage the workforce in open conversations about workforce needs. Further, educators find that we are all talking about the same thing but using our areas of expertise to communicate, which may not be understandable to other stakeholders.

Establishing a common vocabulary and understanding is a necessary first step to ensure all can communicate effectively

and align on expectations and goals for the system. Engaging the regional higher education institutions, as well as your workforce partners in the region and the state, to align expectations and goals is a tough first step, but necessary. Each entity has specific needs and goals, so aligning them is a critical step to ensure each entity's priorities are met and that the workforce works together toward common goals, preventing repetition across the workforce.

The most valuable asset for leaders is our time, and using it to focus on common goals is a conscious way to build strong working relationships and avoid repetition. Unnecessary meetings are momentum killers, so making sure the focus is shared and collaborative to address needs is an important step to keep momentum going for our students' career readiness.

Second, once the shared vision is established, aligning with existing systems or pathways is a critical next step to avoid creating redundancy. A great person once said, *"Why reinvent the wheel when it works,"* and so many times systems in the workforce and education exist, but because of a lack of communication or regional needs, alignment and access to those systems do not exist. If systems are successful, why not connect education and the workforce so that added startup costs or time to implement the system are not wasted? Connecting existing resources is more fiscally responsible and feasible, so taxpayer dollars and workforce investment funds are utilized for maximum impact. Further, connecting K12 to higher education through dual enrollment or a workforce training model is critical, as many states already have these models, which increase student access and exposure to high-quality careers they may not have encountered in their education. Access for rural students is a critical barrier to overcome, so ensuring the system is aligned with access is a crucial step toward overall student success. Also, partnerships and collaboration create a mutually beneficial relationship that meets the needs of all, and the education system considers regional employment needs. Too often, education systems are labeled as not listening to the workforce. By ensuring this collaboration includes workforce

models aligned with educational priorities, it is a great way to build buy-in from all stakeholders and truly create a collaborative model where all goals and needs are addressed.

Third, providing students with work-based learning experiences is a key component, as this represents a shift in traditional education: you apply the knowledge and skills you have learned to the process rather than just preparing for high-stakes tests. Application of knowledge is a key component of student success, so why not train students earlier in their educational careers to apply it? Districts have taught the test to improve results; why not teach career development so students acquire the skills needed to succeed? My district implemented an elementary agricultural career academy for grades 3 through 5 that integrates science, math, and agricultural concepts into the classroom, exposing students to more than just ranching and farming, but also ecology and other ideas that apply to vocational agriculture. Students are using multiple skills at once rather than focusing solely on ELA or math. By integrating skills across the curriculum, students are prepared earlier to multitask and develop stackable, transferable career skills, enabling them to adapt to and shift toward their career goals and needs.

Furthermore, career readiness skills are addressed earlier and continually throughout students' K-12 educational experience, so they are better prepared for the workforce. Continual practice and emphasis on career readiness are simple concepts, yet they are often ignored early in a student's career. Long-term exposure to these skills helps students better understand career expectations and discover opportunities they might otherwise miss due to their family or socioeconomic background. Exposure to and the persistent development of these skills will better prepare our students for life after high school and enable them to be productive employees and citizens of our society.

Fourth, access in rural areas is difficult, so collaborating with stakeholders to remove barriers is key. In rural areas, you are highly dependent on what is available for access, but students may want access to other opportunities and pathways as well.

Eliminating that barrier is a critical step in allowing students to pursue their dreams and passions. and thinking creatively is primary. Districts in New Mexico may be at least 2 hours from the next closest large city, where more opportunities are available. Using technology, such as virtual labs and online training programs with experts, is critical. COVID taught us one thing: to adapt quickly to educational needs and to address student success in diverse ways.

Using available resources and creating a hub have been steps in New Mexico, as well as looking at travel mobile labs and summer internships or residencies at campuses or workforce centers, so students can be exposed to and trained in the pathways desired. Schools, colleges, and universities cannot offer everything needed, so sharing the burden of pathway exposure and access is a vital step to ensure that students in rural areas have access to high-quality careers that align with state and regional needs for workforce development. Access cannot be a barrier to student success in this era, so creating and developing opportunities for student access is a vital step in pathway and career development. By sharing this responsibility, all stakeholders have a stake in the game and a commitment to work together to get the best results for student success and the development of future employees that align with workforce expectations and objectives.

Finally, using data-driven decision-making while supporting the professional development of key staff and students is a priority. This approach is not new to education, but in the last 30 years, high-stakes testing has taken center stage in student success. Are we not, as educators and leaders, charged with developing students to their highest potential? Not all students want or need to go to college to be successful. Aligning our data systems to show student success, such as industry-recognized credentials, certifications, and licensures, as well as training hours in fields for our staff, is a key component of our system's success. A comprehensive data dashboard aligned to state objectives and goals for the workforce is a key point of our success, as discussions have started on how this sets educational and

workforce priorities. Workforce Solutions issued a $400K grant to address this very need in cooperation with the collaborative, so students and adult learners can have access to high-quality opportunities. Return on investment is necessary, as politicians are increasingly demanding accountability and transparency in their budgetary commitments to these initiatives. By establishing a data dashboard that depicts the true success of the education-workforce collaboration in an understandable picture, it will go a long way toward rural workforce reform investment and access to high-quality careers and jobs. With greater success, the legislature can invest in this initiative during the budget process, enabling comprehensive rural workforce reform and ensuring that all students have access to their desired careers and receive high-quality career-readiness training for their passions and goals while preparing for life after high school graduation.

In conclusion, this framework has worked very well in establishing the necessary relationships and connections to advance career readiness for the state. Rural districts have expanded opportunities for student access and aligned operational expectations with local and regional workforce data. Changes are occurring systemically and collaboratively to meet district and regional workforce needs, a distinct shift from past practice in our state. Collaboration among workforce entities has improved significantly, and all parties are establishing common goals and objectives to share a vision of a well-prepared workforce for generations to come, while addressing the generational poverty in our state that has persisted for decades. The utilized framework is a great tool to use whenever a major system change is being explored or just for a local initiative that needs to be aligned to multi-organizational objectives.

Designing a System That Delivers on Its Promise

By David Y. Verdugo

About the Author



David Y. Verdugo is the Superintendent of the Santa Cruz Valley Unified School District No. 35 in Arizona, a role he has held since 2014. With over 34 years of experience as a teacher, coach, and principal, he has guided his district to significant state and national recognition. Named the 2026 Arizona Superintendent of the Year by AASA and the Arizona School Administrators Association, he was also deemed the 2025 Superintendent of the Year by the Arizona Association of Latino Administrators and Superintendents. His leadership emphasizes data-driven instructional strategies and fostering collaborative governance to support diverse student populations. A graduate of Western New Mexico University and Northern Arizona University, he serves on the WestEd Board of Directors and is an active member of AZALAS. His work focuses on building public confidence through transparent, student-centered leadership.

Introduction

If you and I were sitting down together as fellow school leaders, I would probably begin with a question that has shaped nearly every major decision we have made in Santa Cruz Valley Unified School District No. 35.

When a student walks across the stage at graduation, who have they become?

It is easy to focus on what students have earned or which requirements they have completed. Those things matter, but they only tell part of the story. The question that matters more is who our students are when they leave us.

For many years, the primary measure of success in public education has been graduation itself. We track completed courses, accumulated credits, and academic proficiency. Those measures are important, but they do not fully describe the kind of individuals students become during their time in our schools. Increasingly, school systems across the country have begun asking a deeper question: beyond academic knowledge, what qualities should students carry with them when they leave our classrooms?

Portrait of a Graduate

In Santa Cruz Valley, that conversation unfolded over nearly two years. Parents, educators, students, and community members participated in focus groups, staff discussions, and site council meetings. Together, they helped define the qualities they believed should characterize a graduate of our district.

From those conversations came our Portrait of a Graduate. It serves as a shared vision for our schools and helps guide the decisions we make as a district. It represents our belief that an SCV35 graduate should be prepared not only academically, but also personally and socially for the opportunities and challenges that lie ahead.

Our Portrait identifies four attributes that students should develop during their time with us.

1. They should become *creative and critical thinkers* who are able to analyze information, ask thoughtful questions, and approach problems with curiosity.
2. They should grow into *effective communicators* who can clearly express their ideas, listen to others, and collaborate productively.
3. They should understand their role within their communities as *engaged citizens* who contribute positively to the world around them.
4. They should develop the *resilience* and the skills needed to become *lifelong learners* by taking initiatives in their academic, career and personal growth

These attributes are not tied to a single course or program. Instead, they serve as a framework for the entire district. Teachers use them when designing meaningful learning experiences, students begin to recognize the broader skills they are developing, and families gain a clearer understanding of the purpose behind the work taking place in classrooms.

In many ways, the Portrait of a Graduate functions as our district's North Star. It reminds us that the goal of education is not simply to prepare students for a test or even a diploma. Our responsibility is to prepare them for life.

Once we had clarity about the kind of graduates we hoped to develop, we had to take a careful look at whether our systems supported that vision. One of the first places we examined was how we measure student learning.

Like many districts, we recognized that traditional grading systems do not always reflect what students actually understand. Grades often combine behavior, effort, extra credit, and academic performance into a single percentage. A student might earn an 84 percent in a class, but that number alone does not always communicate what the student truly knows or is able to do independently.

Because of that, our district moved toward a standards-based approach to learning and reporting aligned with Arizona

academic standards. These standards define the knowledge and skills students are expected to master as they prepare for college, careers, or military service. Instruction is guided by those expectations, and grades are designed to reflect a student's level of understanding rather than the number of points they have accumulated.

Teachers gather evidence of learning in a variety of ways, including assessments, projects, assignments, and performance tasks. Instead of relying solely on percentages, students demonstrate progress along a continuum that moves from emerging to developing, then to proficient, and ultimately to extending.

Our goal is for every student to reach the extending level, which reflects a deep and independent understanding of the standards being taught.

Throughout the year, teachers conduct regular checks for understanding so they can adjust instruction and support students where needed. Semester report cards provide families with a clearer picture of how students are progressing on the standards addressed during that reporting period. At the high school level, students still receive traditional letter grades so that a GPA can be calculated, but those grades reflect demonstrated proficiency rather than simple point accumulation.

This shift has gradually begun to influence the culture within our schools. If we say resilience matters, our system must give students opportunities to grow and improve. If we say critical thinking is important, we must look beyond the completion of assignments and examine the depth of student understanding. And if lifelong learning is truly one of our goals, then feedback and reflection must play a central role in the learning process.

Of course, no system functions without the people who bring it to life. The most important factor in any district is the educators working with students every day.

Like many districts across the country, we have faced challenges in recruiting and retaining teachers. Instead of viewing this simply as a staffing issue, we began asking a different question:

how can we intentionally grow educators within our own system?

That question led us to develop a Pathways to Teaching Program in partnership with the University of Arizona. The program is designed for individuals who want to become certified teachers and begin their careers in our district.

Participants in the Pathways to Teaching Program are hired by SCV35 and work in our classrooms while completing their certification requirements. At the same time, they partner with the University of Arizona to complete the state-approved educator preparation program. They complete coursework, fulfill student teaching requirements, pass the required examinations, and earn their teaching certification while receiving mentorship and support within our schools.

What makes this model meaningful is that these individuals are not preparing for the profession from the outside. They are developing within it. They gain real classroom experience, work alongside experienced educators, and grow within the same district they will ultimately serve.

The goal is simple. We want to recruit individuals who care deeply about education, support them through the certification process, and help them build successful teaching careers within our schools.

When I step back and look at the work happening across our district, I do not see a collection of separate initiatives. I see alignment.

We have defined the kind of graduates we want to develop. We have adjusted instruction and grading so they reflect genuine learning. And we are investing in educators who share and support that same philosophy.

For school leaders, the challenge ultimately comes down to coherence. A vision loses its power if the systems surrounding it contradict what we claim to value. We cannot say we value growth while maintaining structures that discourage it. We cannot talk about lifelong learning if we fail to demonstrate it ourselves.

Every system within a district either strengthens the promise we make to students and families, or it weakens it.

If I could offer one reflection to another superintendent, it would be this: clarity must come before strategy. When a district clearly defines who its graduates should become, the work that follows begins to align more naturally. Instruction becomes more purposeful. Grading reflects learning. Professional development moves in the same direction.

When that alignment takes hold, something powerful begins to happen. Students understand expectations. Families gain greater transparency into the learning process. Teachers work within a shared vision. Future educators are cultivated intentionally.

At Santa Cruz Valley Unified School District No. 35, our work is not simply about graduating students or filling teaching positions. We are working to build a system that consistently develops creative and critical thinkers, effective communicators, engaged citizens, and resilient lifelong learners.

That is the work before us, and it is a promise we intend to keep.

PART V

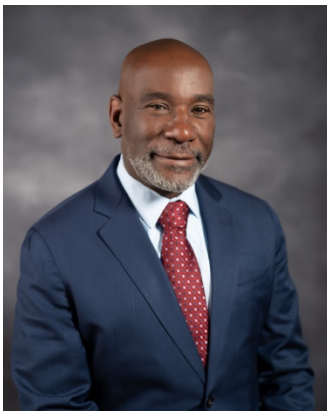
THE INNOVATOR: REIMAGINING WHAT SCHOOL CAN BE

The Innovator: Reimagining the School Calendar

A Superintendent's Perspective

By Dr. Mark Sullivan

About the Author



Dr. Mark Sullivan serves as the Superintendent of Birmingham City Schools, leading the very system he attended as a student. Appointed in 2020, he launched the "Success Starts Here" strategic plan, focusing on literacy, instructional support, and data-driven outcomes. His 30-year career in the district includes roles as teacher, principal, and Chief of Staff, providing him with a unique, empathetic perspective on urban education. Recognized as the 2025–26 Alabama Outstanding Superintendent of the Year, Dr. Sullivan has overseen historic gains in proficiency and state report card rankings. A U.S. Navy Reserve veteran, he brings a disciplined, visible presence to his leadership. He is a staunch advocate for equity, expanding dual enrollment and workforce internships to prepare Birmingham's students for a competitive global economy.

Introduction

Birmingham City Schools, like most school districts across the nation, requires students to attend school for 180 instructional days. As recently as 2016, Alabama permitted districts to operate with as few as 177 instructional days, with the remaining time allocated to professional development for its staff. I understand how we arrived at this number and why the school calendar is structured as it is. What I struggle to understand is why we continue to maintain this model when it no longer appears to be the most effective way to deliver instruction in the present.

Contrary to popular belief, the traditional nine-month school calendar with a long summer break was not driven by agriculture alone. Historically, schools closed during the summer because many buildings lacked air conditioning—particularly in southern states, where schools were chronically underfunded (Pedersen, 2012). Wealthier families in the Northeast often withdrew their children during the hottest months to vacation elsewhere, reinforcing the expectation of a long summer recess (Cunningham, 2022; Villeneuve, 2025). In the mid-19th century, education reformers such as Horace Mann, influenced by the Prussian model, pushed for standardized school calendars—a structure we still largely follow today (Pedersen, 2012).

The question remains:

"Why do we continue to organize schooling this way?"

In the spring of 2020, I was named superintendent of Birmingham City Schools (BCS), a district I know intimately. I come from a family of educators, many of whom worked in BCS, including my mother. I am a graduate of Woodlawn High School, home of the Mighty Colonels. My career began as a substitute teacher in a fourth-grade classroom at North Roebuck Elementary School. From there, I became a permanent classroom teacher and, over the next 25 years, served as a principal at every level from pre-K through 12th grade. I later

held district leadership roles, including principal supervisor, academic officer, and chief of staff.

In April 2020, then-Superintendent Lisa Herring announced her departure from BCS to lead Atlanta Public Schools. Shortly thereafter, I was appointed interim superintendent and officially named the district's next leader in August 2020. At that very moment, the world was shutting down due to a once-in-a-century global pandemic.

The Shift due to the Pandemic

At the time, BCS served nearly 21,000 students across 43 school campuses. The district's student population was approximately 89% African American and 11% Hispanic\Latino with roughly 87% of students qualifying for free or reduced-price lunch. Even before the pandemic, BCS faced significant challenges. Instructionally, we were a highly traditional district with few innovative programs. Technologically, we had only about 6,000 devices—iPads, Chromebooks, and laptops combined—highlighting a significant digital divide.

The pandemic forced us to rethink educational delivery, leverage technology, and confront years of systemic inequities head-on. Lacking sufficient devices or a learning management system, we initially provided instruction through pencil-and-paper assignment drop-offs, with no reliable method for grading or evaluating student learning. Assignments were compiled into large plastic containers for parents to collect. This was our reality from April through May 2020. At one school, the process deteriorated so badly that local media ran a story showing piles of discarded student assignments strewn across the campus. As a district, we struggled to reach the end of the 2019–2020 school year.

We had to adapt quickly if we were going to provide our students with the high-quality education they deserved. During the summer of 2020, we invested heavily in purchasing electronic devices and training teachers to deliver instruction in a virtual

environment. Our goal was to be prepared to return in the fall either face-to-face or synchronously online. I told our educators that we needed to teach like we had never taught before—virtually—so that when the pandemic ended, we would be prepared to teach like we had never taught before as students attempted to make up multiple grade levels of learning in a single year.

Throughout the 2020–2021 academic year, BCS vacillated between virtual and hybrid instruction. In Alabama, the governor granted local superintendents the authority to determine whether schools would remain open or closed, operate virtually or in person, and require masks. There was never a right decision. Whatever choice was made, half of the community would be upset. I developed very thick skin during that time. We attempted to follow CDC guidance, but recommendations changed constantly—from six-foot distancing to three-foot distancing and so on and so on. The human toll was traumatic. Over those two years, BCS lost eight staff members to COVID-19. Two teachers from the same school heartbreakingly died in the same week. It was an incredibly difficult period, and words of sympathy could only go so far.

As the 2020–2021 school year ended, there appeared to be light at the end of the tunnel. COVID-19 cases declined, and vaccines became available. The district aggressively worked to vaccinate staff and students, partnering with local health agencies and the University of Alabama at Birmingham to convert several schools into mass vaccination sites.

The Emperor

That spring, state assessment data was released. The results were unsurprising and alarming. Reading scores were poor, math scores were dismal, and 15 BCS schools received an "F" rating. My mind became consumed with how to address unfinished learning. Returning to business as usual was not an option after nearly two years of inconsistent schooling. Even before the pandemic, we confronted the effects of "summer

slide": the decline in reading and math skills students in historically disadvantaged communities encounter without high-quality summer programming. "COVID slide" was a summer slide on steroids.

I convened my leadership team to discuss ways to address unfinished learning. "Let's run a full summer program in June, remediation, enrichment, credit recovery, grade advancement and then start school back in mid-July," I said. Silence filled the room, followed quickly by animated debate. As I listened, I noticed a pattern: most arguments in favor centered on student needs, while most objections focused on adult needs.
I stopped the conversation. "The data is clear, I said. Our students are significantly behind, and many were struggling even before the pandemic. We have $119 million in ESSER funding. If we cannot do something different in the midst of a global crisis, when the entire world shuts down, then when can we?"

The team agreed, out loud at least. In retrospect, I am not sure whether that agreement reflected true conviction or quiet acquiesces. I remember wondering whether I was like the emperor in The Emperor's New Clothes: was my team afraid to challenge a bad idea, or did they truly believe this could transform education in Birmingham City Schools? Either way, their charge was clear, develop a workable calendar. My charge was just as challenging: building community support.
The team researched alternative calendars nationwide and proposed a model with four grading periods, 180 instructional days, approximately 15 days off between grading periods, and a shortened summer break. We designed flexible breaks with extended learning opportunities to reduce the approximately 185 days students were traditionally out of school. We called these breaks Intersession. During Intersession we would provide intensive support in reading and mathematics in elementary and middle school, and grade and credit recovery for high school students. We didn't want Intersession to only be about making up assignments students missed or failed to complete. We wanted **all** students to attend. We would provide enrichment,

field trips, ACT prep classes and wellness camps, and we partnered with community organizations to offer even more enrichment opportunities.

Using ESSER funds, we planned to keep schools open during Intersessions, and provide transportation, breakfast and lunch, and free aftercare for elementary students. Students who participated could receive more than 200 days of instruction annually. From my perspective, the team had hit a home run.
Selling the idea proved far more difficult. I began with the school board—a nine-member, district-elected body. All nine seats were up for election that August, immediately following the proposed calendar's implementation. After presenting the plan, the response was lukewarm at best. Only four members expressed tentative support. One board member who had served on the calendar committee did not support it. Unbeknownst to me at the time, opposition was already spreading rapidly throughout the community. Board members were receiving calls urging them to reject the proposal. One member asked me to delay implementation until after the election. Another publicly stated, "That's a long time for students to be in school." I had lost control of the narrative.

With the board president's approval, we launched an extensive outreach effort—surveys, focus groups, town halls, meetings with teacher organizations, robocalls, social media outreach, and hired a public relations firm. I even shot a video explaining the calendar. At one point, it became the most-viewed video on our district's YouTube channel.

The feedback was unequivocal: stakeholders overwhelmingly rejected the calendar. Most parents opposed it, citing concerns about summer employment for their children, vacations, and childcare. Resistance was especially strong among parents of students in magnet programs; some of whom argued their children were not behind. Even after reviewing comparative data showing their schools lagged behind magnet programs statewide, many remained unconvinced. Most employees

opposed the change, citing pandemic exhaustion and the need to recharge. Students were emphatic in their rejection.

The emperor was, indeed, naked.

After reflection, I realized the failure was mine. I assumed that data alone would persuade stakeholders, a classic case of leadership hubris. I needed to understand that after the pandemic people didn't want more disruption. They wanted to get back to some sense of normalcy and a change in the school calendar, no matter the reason, was disruptive. People needed to be heard, and their perspectives needed to be valued, regardless of what the data showed.

I continued to review the analysis the local PR firm provided us. I realized something critical: when parents were asked about "year-round school," they overwhelmingly said no. When asked about "extended learning opportunities," they overwhelmingly said yes. The only thing that changed was the terminology.

We adjusted our course. We reframed the initiative as extended learning rather than year-round school. We shifted the start date to early August instead of July and highlighted the benefits of voluntary Intersession for enrichment and remediation. Although we reduced Intersession periods during the year from ten days to five, the core goal remained: increase meaningful instructional time and reduce long stretches when students were disengaged from learning.

On March 23, 2021, the school board approved the revised calendar by a 7–2 vote. Today, it is simply known as the Intersession calendar.

Implementation began in the 2021–2022 school year. Intersessions followed each nine-week grading period. We hired the Public Affairs Research Council of Alabama (PARCA) as a third-party evaluator to show the effects of Intersession on student outcomes. Staffing was voluntary, but teachers who worked intersession were paid $60 per hour; while those who

did not were given the week to rest and recharge. Bus drivers and cafeteria staff were compensated above their regular rates. Staff signed up and the students followed.

That first intersession, 1,800 out of 20,000 students attended. We were disappointed but not deterred, we continued with messaging on the benefits of extended learning. We used partnerships with six local universities to hire and train college students to deliver high dose tutoring during intersession and throughout the year. By the spring of that year we had nearly 7,000 students in intersession. That is 1/3 of our total enrollment in school during a week when they didn't have to be there!

The summer intersession was even more well attended. We called our summer intersession "Sensational Summer of Learning" and nearly 10,000 students showed up.

This year, 2025/26, starts our 6th year of the intersession calendar. ESSER funding for intersession ended in 2023, but we were able to continue the program. Thanks to strong data in grades 3–7, participating students consistently outperformed non-participants, registering gains of up to 22 points versus 13 points in grade 3. Furthermore, the data showed that the more intersessions a student attended the better the student performed on the state assessment.

Armed with this information our team, led by our chief academic and accountability officer Dr. Pamela Williams, went to our state legislature and lobbied for additional funding to continue the program. In 2024 the state legislature allocated $1.8 million dollars to continue intersession in Birmingham City Schools. An additional $1.8 million was allocated in the 2025 state budget.

The emperor was wearing a 3-piece suit.

By 2022–23, researchers reported that Alabama was the only state where average math scores exceeded pre-pandemic levels.

Birmingham City schools was cited for making up nearly half a grade level in math in a single year, outpacing national recovery (Education Recovery Scorecard). Local and national media highlighted the district's gains and the intersession strategy as a lever for recovery.

In addition to intersession, the school district's academic team developed an intentional strategy to bolster teaching and learning throughout the typical school year. This collaborative work led to the district's improved test scores, reducing the number of schools receiving an F from 15 to one, and achieving the highest grade ever on the State Report Card.

Over the last five years we implemented clear districtwide instructional frameworks in Math and English Language Arts to strengthen Tier 1 core instruction, ensure consistent lesson design, and improve alignment to standards across classrooms and schools. The frameworks were initially developed to address the learning loss due to the Covid Pandemic. The BCS Curriculum and Instruction Team was charged with developing and implementing strategies to ensure high quality instruction in all classrooms. The Instructional Frameworks put in place aligned with evidence-based practices that translated into coherent and replicable practices for teaching and learning to produce academic improvement.

We focused on explicit instruction, formative assessment and student collaboration. We established structured literacy support for secondary students scoring in Levels 1–2, including scheduled intervention blocks, skill-focused small groups, and progress monitoring to accelerate foundational reading and comprehension needed for success in core content. Like many other school districts around the nation, reading achievement declined during the Pandemic, especially in grades 6 -12. The district worked with external partners to implement a program of support.

We expanded ACT preparation through districtwide tutoring supports (in-school, after-school, and/or virtual), focusing on

high-impact skill gaps, test strategies, and practice routines to raise readiness and performance. Although emphasis during the Pandemic shifted from ACT, we knew that our students needed more support to increase their benchmark scores on the ACT. The district partnered with organizations to provide additional ACT tutoring in all high schools for students in the 11th grade.

We strengthened teacher capacity through Science of Reading-aligned professional learning emphasizing explicit instruction in phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension—building a stronger foundation for literacy growth. The district was very intentional in making sure that all K-3 teachers were provided with Science of Reading training. Also, specific steps were taken to ensure that the literacy curriculum aligned with the Science of Reading.

We also implemented common assessments in Math and ELA to create consistent measures of student learning, enable school-to-school comparability, support data-driven PLC cycles, and guide timely instructional adjustments and interventions. The district used its various platforms to implement the assessments and train teachers and administrators how to access the data.

Intersession has been a key contributor to the overall academic gains throughout Birmingham City Schools in recent years. However, Intersession, as well as other transformative academic initiatives, have proven to be a lifeline for students and families. If there is a single leadership lesson in our Birmingham City Schools calendar journey, it is this, design for learning, then engineer for feasibility. We have and will keep refining intersessions, tightening curriculum alignment, improving attendance, and expanding enrichment. By leveraging additional instructional time, personalized support, and community collaboration, Birmingham City Schools is not only closing gaps but building futures. We are proving that when students are given the time and tools they need, every child can thrive. The calendar we inherited is not the calendar we must keep. It is simply where we began.

The Pandemic presented us with an opportunity to develop initiatives to make transformative change in our school district. By strengthening our Tier 1 instruction, collecting data and using it to direct academic needs, providing high dosage tutoring, partnering with the District Management Group to develop improvement cycles focused on results, and changing our district calendar, we also altered the mindset in our community. This showed that innovation was possible and that BCS could live up to its vision of being a recognized leader in public education.

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Delivering World-Class Education on the Range

By Dr. Noel Schmidt

About the Author



Dr. Noel Schmidt is the Superintendent of Rock Ridge Public Schools in Minnesota, where he successfully navigated one of the most complex district consolidations in recent history. By uniting the historically rival Virginia and Eveleth-Gilbert communities under a "Fiercely United" banner, he secured support for state-of-the-art facilities and academy-style learning models. His expertise in change management was critical in aligning administrative operations and building public trust during the global pandemic. Dr. Schmidt is a vocal champion for rural education, arguing that small districts deserve the same innovative resources as urban counterparts. His leadership is defined by curriculum transparency, social equity, and high expectations for student achievement. He remains a pivotal figure in Minnesota education, driving a culture of resilience and unity across the Iron Range. This chapter sets an example for what the future of schools should look like from within.

Rock Ridge School District in rural Northern Minnesota is undergoing a transformation. Created by the merger of two ancient rival districts, the Eveleth-Gilbert and Virginia school districts, the citizens of both districts voted to build a new high school and two new elementary schools. The citizens of both school districts also voted to consolidate the two districts into one. This is the first newly consolidated school district in the State of Minnesota in the past fifteen years. And it is probably one of the rarest school consolidations to have occurred, not because of financial struggles, both school districts were in solid financial shape, but because of a genuine interest in improving the quality of the education students were receiving. In other words, the communities set aside their parochial armor and gunpowder and looked to the future for their kids and grandkids. The communities cared less about their old mascots, colors, slogans, and sports history and more about transforming education.

Here is what this means for students who are currently attending or will attend the Rock Ridge schools. The new schools were designed around the 21st-century skills of Critical Thinking, Communication, Collaboration, Creativity, Citizenship, Character, Entrepreneurship, and Global Competence. Our goal is to have the benchmarking standard of "Best in the World," while using simple but powerful statements such as "Education to inspire the next generation," "Fiercely United," "Rock Ridge Rising," and "Helping students find their magnificent obsession," as terms to express ways of thinking about things.
How we view things makes all the difference between success and failure. To that end, here is what we are not striving for. We are not striving to reflect statements such as, "We're okay." Or "Could be worse." Or "At least we're better than *(fill in the blank with the name of another school district)*." These are Trojan horse comparisons. In the world of life, our students' real competition will not be other students on the Range. Rather, the competition will be with other students from around the world and the United States- Alabama, Brazil, Texas, France, Germany, California, South Africa, Massachusetts, Japan, etc.

This is why we have completed construction of a new high school designed around Career Academies. The building opened in the Fall of 2023 and was recently named the 2025 McConnell Award winner for the best educationally designed school in the world. The high school was designed on the premise that we should help our students make better decisions about their future and the world of work. For example, we want to give our students hands-on projects related to fields that interest them. We want to give our students direct contact with people who work in the field, rather than waiting for students to "figure it out in college." The world is full of students who changed majors in their sophomore or junior year of college and suddenly found themselves thousands of dollars in debt with no marketable skills. We wanted to design a better system.

At Rock Ridge, we did.

The foundation of our Rock Ridge K-12 system is shifting to a culture of thinking, in which students will need to actually think during the school day. And by thinking, I don't mean filling out simple worksheets and looking up answers in a textbook — I mean actually thinking, making predictions, running simulations, doing analysis, and solving problems on their own. Imagine that.

The reality is that many students go to school every day and do very little thinking — national studies bear this out. For example, at the national level, in elementary schools, about 76% of students are engaged with the material presented by the teacher. However, by the time students are in high school, this level of engagement drops to 44%. And the number of questions students ask drops from nearly 100% in the early elementary years to an abysmal 25% in high school. Neither of these are good trends.

To counteract these disturbing national trends, at Rock Ridge, we are shifting to more project-based, hands-on, relevant learning. This still involves traditional teaching methods and whole-class instruction. Because, after all, we can't tell students

to make a prediction about something they know nothing about. This is where many schools go wrong. They assume that once freed from the shackles of the teacher, students will magically solve problems they know nothing about. This doesn't work. It is a waste of time to spend a considerable amount of time trying to solve a problem in which you know little to nothing. This is called a pooling of ignorance. The key is to provide the right amount of whole-class instruction, the right amount of group instruction, and the right amount of individual and small-group teaching. This is why effective teaching is so hard.

To design a culture of thinking, we also need to embrace failure. It is only through failure that any of us really learn anything. Most adults who are highly skilled in their jobs were probably not very good when they started. In fact, they probably failed more often than they succeeded. But the key to success is picking yourself up from failure, adjusting your approach to learning, and trying again. Nobody does it perfectly the first time. This means that at Rock Ridge, we need a culture of failure, where students learn that it is okay to fail and not be good at things the first time they try. But through persistence and thinking about what we are trying to learn, we will get better. Sometimes, we sugarcoat things for our kids and tell them how easy things will be. This isn't true, and learning is often hard work. We are better off preparing our students to fail and teaching them how to learn from it so they can readjust and propel themselves to ever higher levels of success.

An important part of a focus on the Career Academy and project-based learning is the design process. The design process has been around for years and is not new. The design process is also applicable to all subjects and problems. (It just isn't thought of often in this way.) We need a design process because students need to be taught a way to think about solving problems. It doesn't work to simply tell a student to "think it through" and hope a dash of fairy dust intervenes, the light bulb comes on, a miracle occurs, and the student ends up with a brilliant product. For those who want to know, the design process typically includes giving the student a challenging problem or question,

then having sustained inquiry to understand the problem or question, followed by a real-world application of the problem or question, which includes some student voice and choice, which then is followed by reflection, which leads to a planned and orderly critique and revision of what went right and what went wrong. Ultimately, there is some type of product that is more public than just the student.

Along this journey, Rock Ridge is committed, even fanatically, I appropriately say, to paying attention to neuroscience, how the brain really learns, and what educational researchers have discovered works and doesn't work. Many educational practices in America continue to be based on little research or brain research. They continue because that is what has been done for the last 50 or 100 years in education.

Let's actually pay attention to what the educational researchers and neuroscientists are saying.

At Rock Ridge, we also believe in the value of inquiry and questioning. We know that **helping students actually think is the key to everything.** This means having students teach concepts to other students. (Note: Teaching concepts to others is one of the best ways to remember what we have learned.) This means having students explain, out loud and step by step, how they got their answer. This means involving students in small groups that have spirited, evidence-based intellectual conversations, not what they heard through the grapevine or on the playground. Or what they want to be true.

To this end, our students' skills are critical. No significant learning can occur if our Rock Ridge students aren't confident, can't advocate for themselves, can't learn from failure, can't learn how to control their emotions, and can't learn how to work with other students, teachers, and future employers. The number one reason adults get fired from the workplace has nothing to do with their intelligence or knowledge of the work they perform. It is because they have poor social and emotional skills and can't work well with others. We believe we should pay

attention to our students' social-emotional skills. This is why we are using the Leader in Me program, modeled after the landmark book, *7 Habits of Highly Effective People*.

Through backward design — beginning with the end in mind — or a portrait of a graduate, we are working to create an educational environment conducive to exemplary learning while giving students the real skills they will need in the future. Both in the home and at work.

The future is here. And the time is now. At Rock Ridge, we are excited about the prospects for our students and our communities. Laurentian Elementary School has been open since the fall of 2022. (In fact, it won a prestigious design award–the John Shaw award–for best architectural design in thirteen midwestern states and the province of Ontario, Canada.) North Star Elementary School opened in the fall of 2024.

But even more important than the buildings are the teaching transformations and the ways students learn, which are happening along the way. A building is just a building. But with the Rock Ridge teachers and staff, the teaching and learning is going to absolutely rock and roll.

Differentiating Instruction for Neurodiverse Learners in Every Classroom

Access, Rigor, and the Responsibility to Evolve

By Dr. Debbie Brockett

About the Author



Dr. Debbie Brockett is an educational consultant and former district superintendent with more than 30 years of experience in K–12 education. She has served as a superintendent, regional superintendent, secondary principal, and central office leader, with a career emphasis on inclusive systems, instructional leadership, and equitable access to high-quality learning. Her work focuses on supporting districts and leadership teams in designing differentiated, research-aligned instructional practices that meet the needs of neurodiverse learners and strengthen outcomes for all students.

Differentiation as an Educational Imperative

Every student has the right to access the full general education curriculum. This right does not change because a learner is neurodiverse, is acquiring English, is struggling academically, or is mastering content more quickly than peers. Students with diverse learning needs do not lack the ability to learn; they simply learn differently. When classrooms are designed around an assumed "average" learner, many students are unintentionally excluded. When instruction is designed to accommodate variability, all students are provided with meaningful opportunities to succeed.

Neurodiversity reflects the natural range of differences in how human brains process information, regulate attention, communicate, and engage with learning. It includes students with autism, ADHD, dyslexia, emotional or executive functioning differences, and identified disabilities, as well as English learners, students who struggle without formal identification, and students whose abilities significantly exceed grade-level expectations. Research confirms that learner variability is the norm rather than the exception (CAST, 2018; Rose, Meyer, & Gordon, 2014). The critical question is not whether diversity exists in classrooms, but whether instructional design acknowledges and responds to it.

The Limits of Labels and the Cost of Lowered Expectations

Historically, schools have attempted to manage difference by sorting students into programs, labels, and placements. While specialized services remain essential, this approach has too often removed responsibility for rigorous instruction from the general education classroom. Differentiation represents a fundamental shift. It recognizes that variability must be anticipated from the outset rather than accommodated after failure. Universal Design for Learning (UDL) and differentiated instruction both emphasize proactive planning that provides multiple means of

engagement, representation, and expression so all students can access high-level learning (CAST, 2018; Tomlinson, 2017).

Too often, a label becomes a ceiling. When students are identified as special education or English learners, expectations are frequently lowered rather than instruction strengthened. Rigor is reduced instead of strategically scaffolded. Over time, this practice limits exposure to complex thinking and reinforces opportunity gaps (Harry & Klingner, 2014). Students internalize diminished expectations, and systems quietly justify underperformance.

The same failure to differentiate negatively affects advanced learners. Gifted students are frequently provided the same instruction as their peers, only at a faster pace. Research has demonstrated that the absence of appropriate challenge contributes to disengagement, under- achievement, and behavioral issues among advanced learners (Reis & Renzulli, 2010). When instruction is designed only for the middle, students on both ends are underserved.

Differentiation as High-Expectations Instructions

Differentiation is not the lowering of standards. It is the deliberate design of instruction that maintains high expectations while varying the supports and pathways used to reach them. Effective differentiation begins with absolute clarity about the learning objective. Teachers must identify what students are expected to know, understand, and be able to do—and ensure students themselves understand that objective. From there, instruction is engineered to provide multiple entry points, appropriate scaffolds, and multiple opportunities for mastery (Tomlinson, 2017).

In a fifth-grade literacy classroom, a teacher anchored instruction to a grade-level standard focused on analyzing an author's argument. Some students accessed the text through audio and vocabulary-supported digital versions, others through peer-supported close reading, and advanced learners through paired primary-source extensions. All students analyzed claims and evidence. The rigor remained constant; the supports varied.

The result was not fragmentation, but increased engagement and demonstrably stronger comprehension across all groups.

Formative assessment is central to this work. Differentiation depends on continuous feedback loops that inform instructional decisions (Hattie, 2012). Flexible grouping, explicit modeling, structured academic discourse, and purposeful scaffolding replace static whole-group instruction as the dominant model. Whole-class teaching has a role, but it cannot serve as the primary method in classrooms filled with learner variability.

The Expanding Role of Artificial Intelligence

The emergence of artificial intelligence has significantly expanded what is possible in differentiated classrooms. When used responsibly and intentionally, AI enables real-time personalization without compromising rigor. AI-supported platforms can generate leveled texts aligned to the same standard, provide multimodal explanations, translate and scaffold language, offer adaptive practice, and create complex enrichment pathways for advanced learners.

In a middle school mathematics classroom, AI-supported tools provided immediate feedback and targeted practice aligned to the day's learning objective. Students with processing challenges accessed visual modeling and guided prompts. English learners used embedded language supports. Advanced students engaged in AI-generated problem extensions requiring multi-step reasoning. The teacher, freed from producing multiple sets of materials, focused on small-group instruction and formative assessment. Student mastery increased, and student confidence improved.

Research supports the careful integration of technology to support personalization, feedback, and access when grounded in sound pedagogy (Holmes, Bialik, & Fadel, 2019; Pane et al., 2017). For neurodiverse learners, AI can support executive functioning, reading access, written expression, and sustained engagement. For English learners, it can preserve academic rigor while reducing language barriers. For advanced learners, it can

facilitate deeper application and independent inquiry. These tools extend teacher capacity; they do not replace professional expertise.

Leadership Responsibility and Systems Design

For leaders, differentiation requires more than philosophical commitment. Many teachers were trained in systems built on uniform pacing, whole-group instruction, and deficit-based intervention models. Expecting sophisticated differentiation without sustained professional learning is unrealistic. Leadership must focus on capacity-building, coherence, and alignment.

In one district undergoing inclusive reform, leaders recognized that teachers wanted to meet diverse needs but lacked the tools to do so. Rather than adopting isolated programs, they invested in a multi-year professional learning model focused on UDL, formative assessment, and instructional coaching. Collaborative planning time was protected. Walkthrough tools were redesigned to emphasize access, rigor, and engagement. Special education staff were embedded in instructional teams. Over three years, disciplinary referrals declined, special education referrals stabilized, and access to grade-level instruction increased across student groups.

This example illustrates that differentiation is not an initiative. It is a system condition. Leaders are responsible for aligning curriculum, professional learning, technology, evaluation, and support services around a shared commitment to inclusive, high-expectations instruction. Without coherence, differentiation remains dependent on individual teachers rather than embedded in organizational practice.

The Professional Obligation to Evolve

What has always been done is not what should always be done. In every other profession, stagnation is unacceptable. Medicine, finance, engineering, and technology continuously adapt

because the consequences of outdated practice are not tolerated. Businesses that fail to evolve do not survive. Education, however, often continues unchanged because students are required to attend. They arrive each day regardless of instructional quality.

That reality creates a moral responsibility, not permission for complacency. Students are not consumers with alternative options. They are learners whose futures are shaped by the quality of instruction they receive. If educators know more about the brain, learner variability, and effective instructional practice, then they are obligated to act on that knowledge.

Differentiating instruction for neurodiverse learners is not about accommodation after failure. It is about designing classrooms where variability is anticipated, rigor is preserved, and every student is viewed as capable of complex thinking. When instruction is intentionally engineered, supported by modern tools, and guided by strong leadership, classrooms become places where difference is not managed, but leveraged. In such environments, access to the general education curriculum is no longer aspirational. It has become the standard.

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They said yes to being vulnerable. Yes to sharing not just their victories but their failures. Yes to opening their playbooks so that other leaders — people they may never meet — could learn from their experiences. That generosity is rare, and we do not take it for granted.

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And to every school leader who picks up this book - you are the reason it was written. We hope it serves you well.

With gratitude,

The TomoClub Team

ABOUT TOMOCLUB

TomoClub (Tomorrow Innovations Inc) was founded with a simple conviction: our students deserve to be future-ready, and the people best positioned to make that happen are already inside the schools.

We work alongside school leaders, educators, and districts to build the skills, systems, and cultures that prepare students for a world that is changing faster than ever.

Our work spans three areas:

FUTURE-READY SKILLS CURRICULUM

A comprehensive K–12 curriculum covering leadership, innovation, resilience, collaboration, emotional intelligence, and creative problem-solving — the capabilities that no technology can replace.

AI IN EDUCATION

Professional development for educators on AI integration, plus an AI Literacy Program for middle and high school students. We believe educators should lead the conversation about technology in learning, not chase it.

SCHOOL LEADER COMMUNITY

Through our podcast (150+ episodes), Educational Hall of Fame, and now this book, we have built a community of school leaders who learn from each other. Because the best answers to the hardest problems in education usually come from other practitioners.

Learn more at tomoclub.org

Follow us on LinkedIn: TomoClub

MEET THE AUTHORS

Connect with the leaders behind these chapters. Each author welcomes professional connections and conversations about the topics in their chapters.

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THE TOMOCLUB PODCAST

The conversations that inspired this book did not start in a boardroom. They started on a podcast.

Over 150 episodes, we have sat down with superintendents, principals, chief academic officers, curriculum directors, and educators from public, independent, and charter schools across the country. We have talked about everything from classroom engagement to post-pandemic behavioral challenges, from technology innovation to the future of schools.

Many of the authors in this book were guests on the show first. Their stories were so compelling that listeners told us they deserved a permanent home — a place leaders could return to. That feedback became this book.

The podcast continues. If the chapters in this book resonated with you, you will find hundreds of hours of practitioner wisdom waiting for you.

Listen wherever you get your podcasts.

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JOIN THE COMMUNITY

This book is the beginning of a conversation, not the end of one.

If you are a school leader who wants to connect with peers who are navigating the same challenges, we have built a community for you.

LEADERS OF TOMORROW COMMUNITY

A private space for school leaders committed to being future-ready. Share resources, ask questions, and learn from practitioners across the country.

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Website: tomoclub.org

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Slack: TomoCircle

Email: info@tomoclub.org

Podcast: Available on Apple Podcasts, Spotify, YouTube, and all major platforms

Thank you for reading.

Now go lead.

TomoClub

LEADERS OF TOMORROW

"The best school leaders are not waiting for the storm to pass. They are building in the storm."

Education is under siege. From AI disruption and teacher shortages to political polarization and declining enrollment, school leaders face more pressure than at any point in modern history.

This book is not another framework from the outside looking in. It is 15 chapters written by the people who run schools — superintendents, principals, and system leaders who are solving these problems right now, in real districts, with real students counting on them.

Each chapter is a battle-tested strategy from the trenches of American education. No theory. No consultants. Just practitioners telling the truth about what actually worked.

15	12	400+	30+
AUTHORS	STATES	YEARS EXP.	DISTRICTS LED

Featuring 15 School Leaders and Their Untold Stories

A Future Ready Schools Collection